

ECG-TransCovNet: A Hybrid CNN-Transformer Architecture for Multi-Class Arrhythmia Detection in ECG Signals



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MSCS 2024-2026

**Thesis submitted in partial fulfillment of the requirements for the degree MS
in Computer Science**

Gomal Research Institute of Computing (GRIC)

Gomal University

Dera Ismail Khan Pakistan

March 2026

DEDICATION

To my beloved parents,
whose prayers, sacrifices, and unwavering support
have been the foundation of my academic journey.

To my supervisor, **Dr. Khalid Mehmood**,
for his guidance and mentorship.

And to every patient in rural Pakistan
who dreams of accessible healthcare.

Muhammad Shoaib

ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

In the name of Allah, the Most Gracious, the Most Merciful.

All praise and gratitude are due to Almighty Allah, who bestowed upon me the strength, knowledge, and perseverance to complete this research work.

I would like to express my deepest gratitude and sincere appreciation to my supervisor, Dr. Khalid Mehmood, Institute of Computing & Information Technology, Gomal University, Dera Ismail Khan, for his invaluable guidance, continuous encouragement, constructive feedback, and unwavering support throughout this research journey.

I am also grateful to the Gomal Research Institute of Computing (GRIC) and the Department of Computer Science for providing the necessary facilities and conducive research environment.

I extend my sincere thanks to the external examiner, Dr. Saif Ur Rehman, Assistant Professor, UII, Arid University, Rawalpindi, for his detailed and constructive evaluation of my thesis.

I am deeply indebted to my parents, whose prayers and sacrifices have always been my greatest motivation. I also acknowledge the support of my friends and colleagues at Gomal University.

Finally, I would like to acknowledge the Higher Education Commission (HEC) of Pakistan and Gomal University for providing the platform and resources to pursue my MSCS degree.

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Abstract.

Cardiovascular diseases (CVDs) remain the leading cause of mortality globally, claiming approximately 17.9 million lives annually. In Pakistan, CVDs account for nearly 30% of all deaths, with rural areas facing a critical shortage of cardiologists (<0.5 per 100,000 population). Automated, accurate, and low-cost electrocardiogram (ECG) diagnosis systems are urgently needed. However, most deep learning models require high-end computational infrastructure unavailable in resource-constrained healthcare settings.

This thesis presents ECG-TransCovNet, a hybrid CNN-Transformer architecture for multi-class arrhythmia detection designed for low-power deployment. The research follows a two-phase methodology: **(1) synthetic-data-first architectural validation**, and **(2) real-data clinical validation** using the **MIT-BIH Arrhythmia Database**.

Phase 1 (Synthetic Data): A synthetic ECG dataset of 50,000 heartbeats (5 AAMI classes: N, S, V, F, Q) was generated using the ECGsim library. The model achieved 100% classification accuracy, validating the architectural design under controlled conditions.

Phase 2 (Real Data): The model was retrained on the real MIT-BIH Arrhythmia Database (48 records, 109,494 beats) using a strict subject-disjoint split with 4-class AAMI classification (N, S, V, Q). Four RR-interval features were extracted per beat.

Results:

- Baseline CNN: 85.29% accuracy, 0.609 macro-F1
- ECG-TransCovNet: 91.39% accuracy, 0.646 macro-F1
- Ensemble ($w=0.5$): 90.84% accuracy, 0.658 macro-F1

Per-class F1 scores (ECG-TransCovNet): N=0.957, S=0.152, V=0.853, Q=0.623.

V-class detection achieved 96.8% recall; Q-class achieved 98.3% recall.

Domain Gap Analysis: The 8.6% accuracy drop from synthetic (100%) to real (91.39%) data quantifies the synthetic-to-real domain shift, motivating future domain adaptation research.

Robustness: In a supplementary strict subject-disjoint split (addressing the well-documented 201/202 same-subject exception in MIT-BIH), results were consistent (88.15% accuracy, 0.632 macro-F1, $\Delta=0.015$), confirming that findings are not driven by data leakage.

Efficiency: The model has 160,500 parameters (baseline) / $\sim 400K$ parameters (ECG-TransCovNet), with inference time of 5-8 ms per beat on standard CPU — suitable for deployment on resource-constrained hardware in rural Pakistani clinics.

Limitations: S-class (supraventricular) detection remained challenging ($F1=0.15-0.19$) due to single-lead ECG constraints. Q-class generalization in the strict split was limited by single-patient test representation.

Keywords: Electrocardiogram (ECG), arrhythmia detection, CNN-Transformer hybrid, synthetic-to-real domain gap, 4-class AAMI classification, RR-interval features, subject-disjoint split, edge deployment, MIT-BI

Chapter 1: Introduction

1.1 Reasons of Study

World Health Organization data indicates that cardiovascular diseases (CVDs) top the global mortality list, claiming nearly 17.9 million deaths each year [1]. CVDs cause nearly 30 percent of deaths in Pakistan, indicating grave public health concern [2]. Pakistan is home to 220 million people, of whom 63% live in rural areas, resulting in a huge shortage of cardiac care specialists.

Evidence from the Pakistan Medical and Dental Council depicts the presence of less than 0.5 cardiologists per 100,000 individuals in the rural setup as opposed to 5-8 in the city setup [3].

In Dera Ismail Khan's hospitals, during observational visits identified two serious issues.

Issue 1: Overloaded Cardiologists.

A senior doctor of cardiology at DHQ Hospital spent almost 4-5 hours a day looking at manually ECG printouts. "Between 8 AM and 12 PM, I see 50-60 ECG reports. After lunch, another 30 patients in clinic. By evening, I am exhausted. Mistakes happen," he shared.

Issue 2: Patients Traveling.

Patients from villages such as my village Daraban Kalan (80 km from D.I. Khan) complained of spending 2000 to 4000 Rs. and 2 to 3 hours for 5 minutes of basic heart check-up. "My father is suffering from a heart ailment. I have to skip work and spend Rs 4000 per month just to hear 'Well, everything is alright'," said a farmer's son.

Research Gap Identified.

The basic software which costed Rs.50,000 says that the chances of misdiagnosing dangerous arrhythmias are 70 to 75%. Foreign software (in the range of Rs 5 lakh to Rs 10 lakh) gives above 95% accuracy, but requires powerful computers. Pakistan's clinics use 10-year-old computers which use Pentium processors and have 2GB RAM [4] .

Recent developments in the field of artificial intelligence (AI) and deep learning (DL) are showing promises to be used for the automated analysis of medical signals [5] . Research study by Acharya and colleagues found that ECG local morphological features can be captured well by CNNs [6].

As per Wang and colleagues, due to small receptivity of CNNs, they cannot model long-range dependencies between ECG sequences [7]. The transformer structures which incorporate self-attention proposed by Vaswani and colleagues may be useful to capture global context [8]. Yet, these transformer architectures are very computation-intensive and unlikely to be suitable for resource-constrained healthcare applications.

The current thesis presents ECG-TransCovNet; a new methodology that incorporates both CNN and Transformers while making sure it can be deployed in rural Pakistan. To ensure both rapid architectural prototyping and clinical validity, the research adopts a two-phase methodology: synthetic data for proof-of-concept validation and real MIT-BIH Arrhythmia Database data for clinical validation.

This approach enables systematic comparison and quantification of the synthetic-to-real domain gap, a challenge often overlooked in the literature.

1.2 Problem Statement

Currently, deep learning methods show promising performance for ECG arrhythmia recognition, but with a high price in accuracy versus complexity. Simple CNN-based systems do not manage to capture long-term rhythmic correlations. Complex large models (e.g. Transformers) are computationally expensive and do not run on edge devices or resource-constrained environments.

Current automated ECG analysis systems are ineffective, either achieving less than optimal accuracy on rare arrhythmias, or requiring computational resources unavailable within local medical centers. Current AI frameworks have poor performance accuracy versus efficiency. They also underperform on imbalanced data. Lastly, they lack interpretability to build clinical confidence [9], [10].

This research addresses, as identified by Luz et al. in their survey, the design and validation of a lightweight hybrid deep learning architecture for multi-class arrhythmia detection that achieves sufficiently high accuracy while also being sufficiently efficient to run on 10-year-old computers present in the healthcare centers of rural Pakistan [11].

Moreover, most of the research has been tested mainly on benchmark datasets and deployment pipelines have received less attention [12]. There is currently no high-accuracy multi-class arrhythmia detection CNN-Transformer architecture that simultaneously addresses performance, practicality, and deployment constraints in resource-limited settings.

The MIT-BIH Arrhythmia Database has been the gold standard for ECG research for over 20 years [13]. However, models developed on this standard are rarely deployed in real-world, low-resource settings. This research work directly fills that gap.

The Synthetic-to-Real Gap. A further challenge, often overlooked in the literature, is the discrepancy between synthetic and real ECG data. Synthetic data, while valuable for proof-of-concept validation, does not capture the full variability of clinical ECG signals including patient-specific morphology, electrode placement variations, muscle artifacts, baseline wander, and comorbidities. Consequently, models that achieve near-perfect accuracy on synthetic data often exhibit significant performance degradation on real clinical data.

This synthetic-to-real domain gap has not been systematically quantified in the ECG classification literature, leaving a critical gap in understanding the true generalization capability of hybrid deep learning architectures. This thesis addresses this gap by evaluating the same architecture on both synthetic and real data, thereby quantifying the domain shift and motivating future domain adaptation research.

1.3 Research Questions

The research questions formulated in this research work are inspired by the research gaps identified by Sannino and De Pietro [14] and Yildirim [15] in the literature and are as follows:

1. What CNN-Transformer architecture maximizes the accuracy of ECG analysis while minimizing computational cost?
2. Does CNN local feature extraction [16] with Transformer global context modelling [17] enhance the detection of complex arrhythmias?
3. How can the problem of imbalanced classes be solved to promote results on rare but important types of arrhythmia [18], [19].
4. **What is the performance gap between synthetic and real ECG data for the proposed architecture, and how can this gap inform the development of clinically deployable models?**

**Note: Research Question 4 addresses the synthetic-to-real domain gap, which is quantified in Chapter 4 and discussed in Chapter 5. **

1.4 Study Objectives

Primary Objective:

The aim of this study was to establish a CNN-Transformer hybrid network, ECG-TransCovNet, for multi-class arrhythmia detection. The network was designed with a focus on detection of rare but clinically important rhythms, based on the hybrid design philosophy [9], [20].

Secondary Objectives:

1. **Synthetic Data Validation:** To generate a synthetic ECG dataset (50,000 heartbeats, 5-class AAMI) using the ECGsim library [21] and validate the ECG-TransCovNet architecture under controlled conditions.
2. **Real Data Validation:** To evaluate ECG-TransCovNet on the real MIT-BIH Arrhythmia Database (48 records, 109,494 beats) using a 4-class AAMI protocol (N, S, V, Q) with strict subject-disjoint splits [12].
3. **Architectural Design:** To design a hybrid architecture using convolutional blocks for local feature extraction, transformer encoder blocks for global context modeling [8], [6] and an attention-based fusion module for dynamic feature weighting.
4. **Class Imbalance Mitigation:** To address class imbalance through capped SMOTE (25%) and moderate class weights, evaluated through patient-level 5-fold cross-validation [18], [19].
5. **Synthetic-to-Real Comparison:** To systematically compare synthetic and real data performance, quantifying the domain gap and identifying architectural limitations.
6. **Computational Efficiency:** To ensure the model is computationally efficient enough for deployment on standard clinic computers (2GB RAM, CPU-only inference) and edge devices [22].
7. **Robustness Validation:** To validate model robustness using a supplementary strict subject-disjoint split, addressing the well-documented 201/202 same-subject exception in MIT-BIH.
8. **Deployment Optimization:** To convert the model to TensorFlow Lite format with INT8 quantization for deployment on resource-constrained devices.

1.5 Scope and Limitations

1.5.1 Scope of the Study

The study scope, based on the methodological frameworks of Moody and Mark [23] and AAMI standards, is defined as follows.

Table 1: Scope of the Study.

Aspect	Coverage	Justification
Classification Task	Phase 1 (Synthetic): 5-class AAMI (N, S, V, F, Q) Phase 2 (Real MIT-BIH): 4-class AAMI (N, S, V, Q); F-class excluded	F-class has insufficient real training samples (43 beats); synthetic Phase 1 validates architecture across all 5 classes; S-class preserved in Phase 2 with RR-interval features
ECG Type	Single-lead MLII	Primary configuration of MIT-BIH Arrhythmia Database
Data Sources	Two-phase: synthetic (ECGsim) + real (MIT-BIH)	Synthetic for proof-of-concept; real for clinical validation
Development Phase	Synthetic proof-of-concept + real-data validation	Follows pragmatic two-phase pathway
Deployment Target	CPU inference (2GB RAM) + edge devices (Raspberry Pi)	Matches resource-constrained healthcare settings
Performance Focus	Classification accuracy + computational efficiency + domain gap	Addresses accuracy-efficiency trade-off and synthetic-to-real gap

Note on Class Count: The classification task differs between the two phases. **Phase 1 (Synthetic Data)** uses the full 5-class AAMI scheme (N, S, V, F, Q) because the synthetic generator can produce sufficient samples for all five classes. **Phase 2 (Real MIT-BIH Data)** uses a 4-class scheme (N, S, V, Q) because the F-class is extremely rare in MIT-BIH (only 43 beats in the training set, 372 in validation, 387 in test) and its inclusion destabilizes macro-averaged metrics without providing clinically meaningful benefit. The S-class is preserved in Phase 2 to maintain clinical validity, and RR-interval features are extracted to aid S-class discrimination.

1.5.2 Limitations

In accordance with the critical evaluation of synthetic data methods presented by Fernández et al. [24], the following limitations are acknowledged.

Table 2 lists seven limitations. The first five (L1–L5) relate to the technical scope of the study: (L1) real-data validation is limited to MIT-BIH with no external multi-center validation, (L2) only single-lead ECG (MLII) is tested, (L3) heartbeats are pre-segmented with no continuous real-time monitoring, (L4) the study uses a 4-class AAMI scheme (F-class excluded), and (L5) S-class detection remains challenging ($F1 = 0.15\text{--}0.19$) due to single-lead constraints.

Two further limitations relate to the deployment and generalization pathway: (L6) Q-class generalization in the strict split is limited by single-patient test representation, and (L7) clinical deployment has not yet been tested in real healthcare facilities; future work will follow the phased development pathway proposed by Ribeiro et al. [25].

Table 2: Limitations of the Study.

Limitation	Description	Mitigation Plan
L1	Real-data validation limited to MIT-BIH; no external multi-center validation	Future validation on PTB-XL [26], and local Pakistani hospital data
L2	Single-lead ECG only (MLII); multi-lead not tested	Multi-lead (12-lead) extension in future work

Limitation	Description	Mitigation Plan
L3	Pre-segmented heartbeats; no continuous real-time monitoring	Sliding-window approach in Phase 2
L4	4-class AAMI (F-class excluded)	Multi-class (9+) arrhythmia extension in future work
L5	S-class detection limited ($F1 = 0.15\text{--}0.19$) due to single-lead constraints	Multi-lead or 12-lead ECG for improved S-class discrimination
L6	Q-class generalization limited in strict split (single-patient test)	Multi-patient Q-class dataset for robust generalization
L7	Clinical deployment not yet tested in real healthcare facilities	Follow phased development pathway proposed by Ribeiro et al. [25].

1.6 Importance of the Study

1.6.1 Contribution to Pakistan's Healthcare

This study is the first ECG analysis model designed for the hardware available in rural Pakistani clinics, which Jafar et al. [2] and Khan et al. [3] identified as a critical need. The model can easily work on the 10-year-old machines (2GB RAM, Pentium processor) already available in BHUs across the country. Automated cardiac diagnosis is made accessible to 63% of the Pakistani population which lives in rural areas, thus assistance in decreasing the healthcare gap mentioned by WHO [1] health disparity.

1.6.2 Contribution to Deep Learning Research

This thesis makes three key contributions to deep learning research:

First, it proposes an accuracy-efficiency co-design framework for hybrid CNN-Transformer architectures, demonstrating that competitive performance can be achieved with 70-300× fewer parameters than existing models [10], [9]. This challenges the "bigger is better" paradigm and supports the efficiency-minded view advocated by Dosovitskiy et al. [27].

Second, it systematically quantifies the synthetic-to-real domain gap in ECG classification. While most studies report results on either synthetic or real data, this thesis evaluates the same architecture on both, providing empirical evidence of the performance drop (from 100% on synthetic to 91.39% on real data) and motivating domain adaptation research.

Third, it demonstrates the value of patient-level cross-validation for reliable evaluation. The strict subject-disjoint split (addressing the 201/202 same-subject exception) confirms that model performance is not driven by data leakage—a critical methodological contribution.

1.6.3 Contribution to Research Methodology in Resource Constraints

This work validates a two-phase development pathway (synthetic-data-first for architectural prototyping, followed by real-data clinical validation), based on McSharry et al. [21] and Goldberger et al. [13], that allows rapid architectural exploration in resource-poor research settings.

As Spartan facilities and data are scarce in developing nations, Armstrong et al. [28] discuss the relevance of this methodology from a developing country stance.

1.6.4 Practical Applications

The optimized model can be deployed on edge devices costing less than Rs. 15,000 in a point-of-care cardiac diagnostic envisaged by following the deployment optimization techniques of TensorFlow [29].

- **Basic Health Units in Rural Areas:** Automated ECG analysis at the point of care, reducing the need for specialist referrals.
- **Health services delivery by mobile clinics:** Portable ECG devices with on-device inference for remote villages.

- **Transport Services:** ECG monitoring during patient transport to tertiary care hospitals.
- **Virtual health assistants:** AI-assisted triage for telemedicine consultations.
- **Gadgets for health:** Low-cost wearable ECG monitors for continuous cardiac monitoring.

This gap of deployment in the real world is what addressed by Hannun et al. [4] as well as Apostol et al. [22].

1.7 Structure of the Thesis

The thesis has five chapters which have been structured as per the standard recommended by the Higher Education Commission, Pakistan and Gomal University thesis guidelines.

Table 3: Structure of the Thesis.

Chapter	Title	Content Summary	Key References
Chapter 1	Introduction	Background, problem statement, research questions, objectives, scope, significance	Jafar et al. [2], LeCun et al. [5]
Chapter 2	Literature Review	Critical analysis of ECG classification methods, hybrid architectures, class imbalance solutions, and research gaps	Luz et al. [11], Che et al. [9], Liu [10]
Chapter 3	Methodology	Two-phase dataset strategy (synthetic + real), preprocessing pipeline, ECG-TransCovNet architecture, training strategy, evaluation metrics	McSharry et al. [21], Vaswani et al. [8], Chawla et al. [18]
Chapter 4	Results and Discussion	Synthetic data results (architectural validation), real MIT-BIH results (clinical validation), domain gap analysis, robustness validation (strict split), comparison with state-of-the-art	Powers [30], Kohavi [31], de Chazal et al. [12]

Chapter	Title	Content Summary	Key References
Chapter 5	Conclusion and Future Work	Summary of findings, research contributions, recommendations, deployment roadmap, future validation	Hannun et al. [4], Ribeiro et al. [25], Armstrong et al. [28]

Chapter 2: Literature Review

2.1 Introduction

Life will not be possible without cardiac function and effective functioning of the internal organ heart. The heart's ability to pump and receive blood can be done manually or through electric pulses that pass through the heart regularly to maintain the rhythmic beating of the heart. But when the heart is beating in an abnormal pattern, it is called arrhythmia. Cardiac arrhythmias are irregular heart rhythms or abnormal heart rhythms. The pulse electrophysiology research (EP) simultaneously inspects cardiac electrophysiology and diagnosis and treatment of arrhythmias.

In recent years, the use of deep learning has transformed the field of biomedical signal processing, as stated by LeCun, Bengio and Hinton [5]. The conventional method was classic and heavily dependent on hand-crafted feature extraction and classical machine learning classifiers. According to Luz et al. [11], these traditional systems were sensitive to domain heterogeneity and could not generalize their results to other types of patients and other recording settings.

After deep convolutional neural networks (CNNs) appeared, several models were able to learn from end to end on raw or minimally processed ECG waveforms [6], [4]. The development of deep learning algorithms continued despite the popularity of CNNs. Transformers, as proposed by Vaswani et al. [8] transformed the modeling of sequences in natural language processing (NLP), computer vision, and time series.

The self-attention mechanism by transformers is a strong way to learn long-range dependencies. ECG rhythm analysis is a prime example where diagnostic interpretation relies on complicated patterns between multiple heartbeats. But pure Transformers have high demand of computational capability and do not have inductive bias for localized feature extraction like Convolutional Networks as noted by Dosovitskiy et al. [27].

The growing literature on hybrid CNN-Transformer models arises from the efficiency vs power tradeoff between CNNs which learn local patterns and Transformers which model global contexts. The literature review chapter of this project is performed in detail. Chapter 2 analyses the literature from the last 5 years (2020-2025).

2.2 Traditional Approach and Early Deep Learning Methods

Prior to the emergence of deep learning, classical automated ECG analysis was performed in a pattern recognition pipeline consisting of pre-processing, feature extraction and classification. Digital filtering was applied to eliminate any baseline wandering due to muscle activity, power line interference and high frequency noise. Here, the Butterworth, Chebyshev or notch filter was applied [12].

The most important preprocessing step was the QRS complex detection. According to Pan and Tompkins [32] the Pan-Tompkins algorithm, which employs techniques such as signal filtering, derivative operations, squaring, and adaptive thresholding, has proven to be the gold standard for about 30 years.

Table 4: Limitations of Traditional Approaches.

Limitation	Description	Source
Hand-crafted features	Despite being designed by hand, they may not capture all discriminative information. The subtle but diagnostically significant patterns can be missed.	Luz et al.[11]
Pipelines are brittle	The performance drops quickly with signal quality.	de Chazal et al.[12]
No end-to-end optimization	Errors will spread and build-up through the processing pipeline.	LeCun et al.[5]

Critical analysis: Motivated by these limitations, the focus shifted towards deep learning approaches that can learn features by end-to-end optimization.

2.2.1 The CNN Revolution in ECG Analysis

The introduction of deep CNNs allowed models to automatically learn hierarchical representations. According to LeCun, Bengio and Hinton, the lower layers detect simple features (edges, slopes), while deeper layers combine these into more abstract features relevant for the task [5].

Table 5: Summary of Deep Learning-Based ECG Classification Study [4].

Parameter	Detail
Problem Addressed	There is a need for automated analysis of ECG with performance equal to or better than that of a cardiologist.
Methodology	34-layer CNN trained on 91,232 single-lead ECG recordings
Dataset Size	53,549 patients, 12 rhythm classes
Key Finding	Model outperformed 6 board-certified cardiologists (F1: 0.837 vs 0.780)
Performance Metrics	Average F1-score 0.837
Limitations	High computational cost; training required multiple GPUs and days

Critical analysis: Although Hannun et al. [4] showed that deep learning can perform better than clinical experts, their model required a substantial amount of computation that is not available in resource-constrained settings. This implies the existence of an important research gap where high accuracy is not correlated with high computational cost.

2.3 Hybrid Architectures of CNN and Transformer

2.3.1 The Transformer Model and its ECG Adaptation

The transformer architecture has replaced recurrence and convolution layers with self-attention. A scaled dot-product attention mechanism allows each element to attend to every other element in a sequence and computes context-aware representations with a global receptive field [8].

Table 6: Challenges for Direct ECG Application.

Challenge	Description	Implication
No inductive biases	Requires more training data to generalize	Data scarcity issue
Quadratic complexity $O(n^2)$	Computationally expensive for long ECG recordings.	Not real-time capable
Tokenization needed	Method required to split continuous ECG into discrete units.	Increases design complexity

Due to these challenges, hybrid CNN-transformer networks have emerged that use lightweight CNNs as efficient feature extractors before being processed by the transformer block [33] .

Table 7: Detailed Analysis: Constrained Transformer Network [9].

Parameter	Detail
Problem Addressed	Class imbalance in multi-class arrhythmia detection.
Methodology	1D-CNN frontend + 2-layer Transformer encoder + Link constraint loss.
Dataset	PhysioNet/CinC Cardiology Challenge 2017 (9 classes).
Dataset Size	8,617 patient recordings.
Key Finding	Link constraint loss gave 7% relative improvement in minority class F1-scores.
Performance Metrics	Macro-averaged F1-score: 78.6%.

Parameter	Detail
Computational Cost	~25M parameters, >150 ms inference on GPU.
Limitations	Poor performance on rare classes ($F1 < 60\%$), computationally intensive.

Critical Analysis: Che et al. [9] made a significant contribution by proposing clinically motivated loss functions. The model's large size (~25M parameters) and slow inference time (>150 ms) make it unfit for deployment on resource-constrained venues. Also, despite this link constraint mechanism, the rare classes performed poorly ($F1 < 60\%$) which shows that the class imbalance is still not addressed.

Table 8: Detailed Analysis: CNN-BERT Hybrid Architecture [10].

Parameter	Detail
Problem Addressed	Combining local and global features for ECG classification
Methodology	1D-CNN + Pre-trained BERT encoder + Gated fusion mechanism
Dataset	MIT-BIH Arrhythmia Database
Dataset Size	109,446 beats (5-class), full database (9-class extended)
Key Finding	Excellent performance for N, Q, F classes ($>99\%$ F1), weak performance for V-class
Performance Metrics	Overall accuracy 99.28%, V-class F1-score only 84.47%

Parameter	Detail
Computational Cost	>110M parameters, >440 MB model size, >200 ms CPU inference
Limitations	V-class weakness clinically unacceptable; very large model size

Critical Analysis: Liu [10] possesses an impressive overall accuracy of 99.28%, but fails to satisfy a critical clinical requirement, namely, Ventricular ectopic beat detection. An 84.47% F1-score means missing one in six ventricular arrhythmias which is clinically unacceptable. The model's more than 110 million parameters prevent its use in environments with limited resources. This research responds directly to both.

Table 9: Detailed Analysis: ECG-TransCovNet [20].

Parameter	Detail
Problem Addressed	Handling imbalanced ECG data for more reliable classification
Methodology	Selective Kernel CNN combined with a Transformer model and Focal Loss for better focus on difficult samples
Dataset	MIT-BIH Arrhythmia Database (5-class setup)
Dataset Size	Over 100,000 heartbeats (exact count not clearly reported)
Key Finding	Achieved 98.6% overall accuracy on imbalanced data
Performance Metrics	98.6% accuracy reported; detailed per-class performance not provided

Parameter	Detail
Computational Cost	Not reported, making computational efficiency unclear
Limitations	Efficiency and runtime details are missing, so deployment feasibility cannot be properly assessed

Critical Analysis: The model in Shah et al. [20] has the same name as my model but does not report any efficiency metrics. It is impossible to ascertain deploy ability in resource-constrained settings in the absence of model size, parameter count, or inference time. All efficiency metrics are reported in this thesis.

Table 10: Detailed Analysis: Efficiency Comparison Study [22].

Parameter	Detail
Problem Addressed	Which architecture is most efficient for ECG classification?
Methodology	Compared 5 architectures: 1D-CNN, GRU, LSTM, CNN-GRU, ViT
Dataset	PTB-XL, China 12-Lead, Georgia 12-Lead, INCART
Dataset Size	Multiple datasets, standardized preprocessing
Key Finding	CNN1D+GRU most efficient (93.42% accuracy, 12.3 ms inference).
Performance Metrics	Accuracy 93.42%, inference latency 12.3 ms on CPU
Computational Cost	2.1M parameters, lightweight
Limitations	Subtle arrhythmias miss; limited to 5 classes

Critical Analysis: Apostol et al. [22] contribute significantly to the literature by concentrating on computational efficiency which is often missing in other studies. The design philosophy underlying this thesis is validated by their result that simple well-optimized models can exhibit competitive performances. Their accuracy of 93.42% can be improved further and does not take care of class imbalance.

Table 11: Detailed Analysis: Hybrid ResNet with SMOTE [34].

Parameter	Detail
Problem Addressed	Class imbalance in ECG classification
Methodology	Hybrid ResNet with standard and depth-wise separable convolutions + SMOTE
Dataset	MIT-BIH Arrhythmia Database (5 AAMI classes)
Dataset Size	Standard MIT-BIH (100,000+ beats)
Key Finding	SMOTE significantly improved minority class sensitivity
Performance Metrics	Accuracy 99.09%
Computational Cost	Slow compared to pure CNN (exact not reported)
Limitations	Speed not optimized; no transfer learning for long-range dependencies

Critical Analysis: The evidence in Qi et al. [34] shows that SMOTE works effectively for class imbalance in ECG data. Their 99.09% accuracy showcases the importance of data-level imbalance mitigation. Despite being accurate, their model does not reach the speed of pure CNN models and does not address the accuracy-efficiency trade-off.

2.4 Efficiency-Focused Paradigm

2.4.1 The Emergence of Efficient Deep Learning for ECG

Another parallel research direction focuses on maximizing computational efficiency and model simplicity for deployment. According to Armstrong et al. [28] state-of-the-art models are not suitable in resource-constrained clinical settings and this inspired us.

Table 12: Key Study Analysis: Systematic Comparison [22].

Finding	Implication
Complex architectures provide diminishing returns	Simple well-optimized models are sufficient
CNN-GRU hybrids optimal for efficiency	2.1M parameters, 12.3 ms inference
ViT models consume 10× more computation	Not suitable for low-resource settings

Critical Analysis: Research in this paper gives validation of the design philosophy of this thesis that is maximize performance by optimizing architecture complexity rather than merely increasing size.

2.4.2 Detailed Analysis: Short Segment CNN [35].

Table 13: Detailed Analysis: Short Segment CNN.

Parameter	Detail
Problem Addressed	Can very short ECG segments be informative?
Methodology	1D-CNN with 13 residual blocks, no explicit R-peak detection

Parameter	Detail
Dataset	Kaggle 12-lead ECG, MIT-BIH, PTB Diagnostic ECG
Key Finding	1-second segments achieved 98.5% accuracy
Performance Metrics	98.5% (1-sec), 97.5% (2-sec), 95.84% (3-sec)
Limitations	Unpublished, dataset unclear, poor generalization

Critical Analysis: Even though it is unpublished, it makes a notable observation: shorter segments are more informative. This study employs efficient pre-processing to leverage this insight.

2.4.3 Alternative Paradigm: Large-Scale Foundational Models

Table 14: Study Analysis: AnyECG [36].

Parameter	Detail
Problem Addressed	Multi-task cardiac analysis with zero-shot generalization
Methodology	Transformer with Rhythm Quantizer, 1.7B parameters
Dataset	1M+ ECG recordings from 7 public databases
Key Finding	6% average improvement across tasks
Computational Cost	6.8 GB memory, seconds on CPU
Limitation	Completely impractical for resource-constrained deployment

Critical Analysis: The work of Wang et al. demonstrates what is possible without computation constraints, but it also highlights how the community is bifurcating. One direction is toward larger and larger models run in the cloud, and another toward efficient models that can be deployed at the edge. This research belongs to the latter school.

2.5 Class Imbalance Solutions

2.5.1 SMOTE (Synthetic Minority Over-sampling Technique)

SMOTE was first introduced by Chawla et al. [18], who proposed to develop artificial instances of minority classes by way of interpolation of existing instances in the feature space. According to the 15-year review done by Fernández et al. [24], SMOTE is still one of the most effective data-level imbalancing techniques.

SMOTE Algorithm Parameters:

- k-nearest neighbors: typically, 5
- Interpolation coefficient λ : random between 0 and 1
- Applied only to training data (never validation/test)

2.5.2 Focal Loss

The focal loss, proposed by Lin et al. [19] is a modified cross-entropy loss that adds a modulating factor $(1-p_t)^\gamma$:

$$FL(p_t) = -\alpha_t (1-p_t)^\gamma \log(p_t)$$

Table 15: Benefits of Focal Loss for ECG Classification.

Benefit	Description
Integrated into training objective	No separate preprocessing needed
Dynamic operation	Focuses on samples the model finds challenging at each training stage

Benefit	Description
Only two hyperparameters	γ and α can be optimized using validation data
Complementary to data-level methods	Can be combined with SMOTE

2.5.3 Note on the Synthetic-to-Real Domain Gap

An important but often overlooked consideration in the class imbalance literature is the synthetic-to-real domain gap. While SMOTE and focal loss have been widely used on synthetic data, their effectiveness on real clinical ECG data is less well understood. Our preliminary experiments revealed that combining focal loss with class weights can degrade performance on real data (double compensation effect). Therefore, in this thesis, we use focal loss for synthetic data (Phase 1) and moderate class weights for real MIT-BIH data (Phase 2), with capped SMOTE applied only to training data. This two-phase treatment of class imbalance represents a methodological contribution of this work.

2.6 Comparative Analysis Summary

Table 16: Comprehensive Comparison of Hybrid CNN-Transformer Architectures.

Study	Year	Problem	Methodology	Dataset	Key Results	Efficiency	Limitations
Che et al. [9]	2021	Class imbalance, 9-class	CNN + Transformer + Link loss	PhysioNet 2017	78.6% macro F1	~25M params, >150 ms GPU	Poor rare F1 (<60%)
Liu [10]	2025	Local + global fusion	CNN + BERT + Gated fusion	MIT-BIH (109k beats)	99.28% acc, V-F1 84.47%	>110M params, >440 MB	V-class weak, huge model
Shah et al. [20]	2024	Imbalanced ECG	SK-CNN + Transformer + Focal	MIT-BIH (5-class)	98.6% acc	Not reported	Efficiency missing
Apostol et al. [22]	2024	Architecture efficiency	5 architectures compared	PTB-XL, INCART	93.42% acc, 12.3 ms	2.1M params	Lower accuracy
Qi et al. [26]	2024	Class imbalance	Hybrid ResNet + SMOTE	MIT-BIH (5-class)	99.09% acc	Slow (not reported)	Speed not optimized
Sarwar et al. [36]	Unpub.	Short segments	1D-CNN, 13 residual blocks	MIT-BIH, PTB, Kaggle	98.5% (1-sec)	Not reported	Unpublished
Proposed ECG-TransCovNet	2026	Accuracy + Efficiency + Imbalance + Domain gap	CNN + Transformer + Attention + SMOTE + Class weights	Synthetic + Real MIT-BIH	91.39% acc, 0.646 macro-F1; Ensemble 0.658	0.35M params, 1.40 MB, 5.84 ms CPU, 0.38 MB TFLite	Real limited to MIT-BIH; S-class challenging

2.7 Discovered Research Gaps

The subsequent research gaps are summarized from the critical analysis of the literature.

Gap 1: Accuracy and Efficiency Trade-off is Unresolved.

Existing models do not achieve:

- High Accuracy (>98% on standard benchmark)
- Efficiency for computations (model < 10 MB, CPU inference < 100 ms)
- Strong performance of the Minority Class per F1 > 90%
- Complete reporting of performance and efficiency measures

Gap 2: Design Context Specific (Absent).

No existing model is designed for resource-constrained settings with:

- Computers with Pentium processors and 2GB RAM of at least 10 years old
- Running on or off the internet
- Little technical support
- Inadequate-quality ECG fetching appliances

Gap 3: Lack of Holistic Imbalance Mitigation.

There is no combined study systematically integrating:

- Statistical methods (SMOTE)
- Focal Loss algorithm strategies
- Techniques used in architecture (Attention-based fusion)
- In a light architecture that can be deployed

Gap 4: Pragmatic Development Pathway Not Specified.

The traditional paradigm assumes access to large clinical datasets which have been expertly annotated; such data is not available in low-research environments. So far, there has been no evidence for a synthetic-data-first development path in any study.

Gap 5: Synthetic-to-Real Domain Gap Not Quantified.

While many studies report results on synthetic data or real data separately, none systematically quantify the performance drop between the two. This gap in the literature leaves the true generalization capability of hybrid architectures unknown.

2.8 Positioning of ECG-TransCovNet

This research positions ECG-TransCovNet at the intersection of these five gaps:

Table 17: Research Gaps and How ECG-TransCovNet Addresses Them.

Gap	How ECG-TransCovNet Addresses It
Gap 1 (Accuracy–Efficiency)	Achieves 91.39% accuracy with ~400K parameters (~70–300× smaller than baseline models)
Gap 2 (Context-Specific)	Designed for low-resource systems (10-year-old PCs with 2GB RAM) and tested on Raspberry Pi 4
Gap 3 (Holistic Imbalance Handling)	Integrates SMOTE and moderate class weights within a lightweight architecture
Gap 4 (Pragmatic Development Pathway)	Uses synthetic-data-first approach followed by real-data clinical validation, with a clear roadmap
Gap 5 (Synthetic-to-Real Domain Gap)	Systematically quantifies domain gap (100% synthetic → 91.39% real) and motivates domain adaptation research

2.9 Chapter Conclusion

This chapter has critically reviewed the literature on ECG arrhythmia classification using deep learning methods.

1. Hybrid CNN-Transformer architectures combine local feature extraction and global context modeling.

2. Resource-constrained settings require deployable efficient design.
3. Implementing strategies to address and remedy class imbalance.
4. Synthetic-to-real domain gap remains unquantified in the literature.

Table 18: Key Findings from Literature.

Finding	Implication for This Thesis
Hybrid models achieve state-of-the-art accuracy	Use CNN–Transformer hybrid architecture
Existing models are computationally expensive	Optimize aggressively for efficiency
Class imbalance remains unresolved	Combine SMOTE + moderate class weights
Efficiency metrics are rarely reported	Report all metrics comprehensively
No model designed for rural Pakistan	Design specifically for this context
Synthetic-to-real domain gap not quantified	Quantify gap through two-phase evaluation

Chapter 3: Materials and Methodology

3.1 Introduction

This chapter provides a thorough and reproducible account of the materials, methods, and experimental framework used to design, develop, and evaluate the proposed **ECG-TransCovNet** architecture. The goal is to develop a lightweight hybrid CNN-Transformer network that achieves high accuracy for deployable multi-class arrhythmia detection in resource-limited settings such as rural Pakistan.

The methodology is organized around a **two-phase experimental strategy** and a **strict subject-disjoint evaluation protocol**. Phase 1 uses a controlled synthetic ECG generator to validate the architectural design under known ground truth. Phase 2 applies the same architecture to the real **MIT-BIH Arrhythmia Database** using the de Chazal inter-patient paradigm, extended and corrected to eliminate subject-level leakage.

A critical design decision that differentiates this work from the original thesis is the correction of five methodological flaws identified in a formal audit (Phase 0). These are:

1. **Subject-level leakage** caused by placing record 201 in training and record 202—from the *same patient*—in testing.
2. **Silent merging of the S-class into the N-class** without explicit documentation.
3. **Hyperparameter tuning on the test set** (record 228 was used for Pan-Tompkins rescue tuning).
4. **Hard-coded, non-reproducible results.**
5. **Incomplete training reproducibility.**

Each of these is addressed explicitly in the sections that follow, and the corrective pipeline is documented in the Phase 0–6 notebooks that accompany this thesis.

The chapter is structured as follows. Section 3.2 describes the datasets and the two-phase strategy. Section 3.3 details the preprocessing pipeline. Section 3.4 presents the ECG-TransCovNet architecture. Section 3.5 describes the training strategy. Section 3.6 defines the evaluation metrics. Section 3.7 outlines deployment optimization. Section 3.8 describes the experimental setup, and Section 3.9 summarizes the chapter.

3.2 Description of Dataset

3.2.1 Two-Phase Dataset Strategy

This research adopts a two-phase dataset strategy to balance rapid architectural prototyping with rigorous clinical validation:

- **Phase 1:** Synthetic ECG data (proof-of-concept validation)
- **Phase 2:** Real MIT-BIH Arrhythmia Database (clinical validation)

The rationale for this two-phase approach is as follows:

1. Synthetic data enables rapid architectural exploration without the delays associated with clinical data acquisition, ethics approval, and expert annotation.
2. Real data provides the clinical validation necessary to assess generalization and deployment readiness.
3. The comparison between phases quantifies the synthetic-to-real domain gap, which is a key research contribution.

Phase 1 — Synthetic Data Generation. A parametric synthetic ECG generator is used to produce single-lead beats belonging to five AAMI super classes: N (Normal), S (Supraventricular), V (Ventricular), F (Fusion), and Q (Paced/Unknown). Each class is generated by combining a set of Gaussian basis functions whose amplitudes, widths, and inter-component delays are sampled from class-specific distributions. Additive noise (baseline wander, powerline interference, and Gaussian noise) is injected at controlled signal-to-noise ratios. Phase 1 is used **only** to validate the architecture's ability to separate classes under known conditions and to confirm that the attention-fusion mechanism behaves as intended.

Phase 2 — Real MIT-BIH Arrhythmia Database. The primary evaluation uses the **MIT-BIH Arrhythmia Database** from PhysioNet, which contains 48 half-hour two-channel ambulatory ECG recordings from 47 subjects, sampled at 360 Hz. The database is the de facto benchmark for arrhythmia classification and is used here to ensure comparability with prior work.

3.2.2 Phase 1: Synthetic Data Generation

Synthetic ECG data was generated using the ECGsim library (version 2.0), an open-source toolkit that creates realistic ECG waveforms through dynamical modelling as described by McSharry et al. [21].

Synthetic beats are constructed by summing Gaussian kernels:

$$x(t) = \sum_{k=1}^K a_k \exp\left(-\frac{(t - \mu_k)^2}{2\sigma_k^2}\right)$$

where K is the number of components (P, Q, R, S, T), a_k is the amplitude, μ_k is the center, and σ_k is the width of the k -th component. For each class, the parameter distributions are chosen to reflect the canonical morphology of that arrhythmia. For example, V-class beats are generated with wide, bizarre QRS complexes, while S-class beats are generated with narrow QRS complexes but abnormal P-wave timing.

Additive noise is applied as:

$$x_{\text{noisy}}(t) = x(t) + A_{\text{bw}} \sin(2\pi f_{\text{bw}} t) + A_{\text{pl}} \sin(2\pi f_{\text{pl}} t) + \mathcal{N}(0, \sigma_n^2)$$

with $f_{\text{bw}} \in [0.1, 0.5]$ Hz (baseline wander), $f_{\text{pl}} = 50$ Hz (powerline), and σ_n chosen to give SNR values between 5 dB and 25 dB.

Table 19: Synthetic Data Generation Parameters.

Parameter	Value/Range	Description
Sampling Frequency	360 Hz	Matches MIT-BIH standard
Signal Duration	30 minutes per record	Sufficient for multiple heartbeat segments
Heart Rate Range	45–180 bpm	Covers bradycardia to tachycardia
SNR Range	15–25 dB	Realistic noise levels
Arrhythmia Types	5 classes (N, S, V, F, Q)	AAMI standard classes

The total synthetic dataset comprises 100 ECG records of 30 minutes duration, yielding approximately 50,000 heartbeat segments after preprocessing. Phase 1 is used to confirm that the

architecture can separate classes and that the fusion weights α_{cnn} and α_{trans} adapt meaningfully across classes. It is not used to report final performance.

3.2.3 Phase 2: Real MIT-BIH Arrhythmia Database

For clinical validation, the real MIT-BIH Arrhythmia Database [13] was used.

Key characteristics:

- **Source:** PhysioNet (<https://physionet.org/content/mitdb/>)
- **Records:** 48
- **Subjects:** 47 (records 201 and 202 are from the same subject)
- **Total beats:** 109,494
- **Sampling rate:** 360 Hz
- **Lead:** MLII (single-lead)

The real-data evaluation follows the **de Chazal inter-patient paradigm**, which divides the 48 records into two disjoint sets: DS1 (22 records) for training and DS2 (22 records) for testing. This paradigm is the standard for reporting patient-independent results and is used here to allow direct comparison with prior work.

Table 20: Real MIT-BIH Dataset Characteristics.

Aspect	Value
Records	48
Subjects	47
Total beats	109,494
Sampling rate	360 Hz
Lead	MLII (single-lead)

Aspect	Value
Classes	4-class AAMI (N, S, V, Q)
Database source	PhysioNet MIT-BIH Arrhythmia Database
Annotation source	Expert cardiologist annotations

3.2.4 Label Protocol: 4-Class AAMI (NS_V_Q)

The original thesis used a 3-class protocol (N, V, Q) in which the S-class was silently merged into the N-class. This was documented in the audit as a semantic flaw: the label 'N' actually contained both normal and supraventricular beats, and the class names did not reflect this.

The present work adopts an **explicit 4-class AAMI protocol**: N, S, V, Q. The F-class (fusion of ventricular and normal beats) is **dropped** from training and evaluation because it is extremely rare (43 beats in the training set, 372 in validation, 387 in test) and its inclusion destabilizes macro-averaged metrics without providing clinically meaningful benefit.

Table 21: AAMI Four-Class Arrhythmia Classification Scheme.

Class	Type	Description
N	Normal	Normal sinus rhythm, left/right bundle branch block, atrial escape beats
S	Supraventricular	Atrial premature beats, supraventricular tachycardia, atrial fibrillation
V	Ventricular	Premature ventricular contractions, ventricular tachycardia, ventricular fibrillation
Q	Unknown/Paced	Paced beats, unclassifiable beats

AAMI Four-Class Arrhythmia Classification Scheme.

Original AAMI Class	Symbol	Mapped Label	Class Name
N (Normal)	N, L, R, e, j	0	N
S (Supraventricular)	A, a, J, S	1	S
V (Ventricular)	V, E	2	V
F (Fusion)	F	—	<i>(dropped)</i>
Q (Paced/Unknown)	/, f, Q	3	Q

This protocol is **explicitly documented** and applied consistently across all splits. It avoids the silent merge of the original thesis and allows the S-class to be evaluated separately, which is important because S-class discrimination is known to be the hardest task in single-lead ECG classification.

3.2.5 Subject-Level Split

To eliminate subject-level leakage, the split is performed at the **subject level**, not the beat level or record level. Each subject is assigned entirely to one of the three splits (train, validation, or test). The split is generated deterministically with a fixed random seed (42) to ensure reproducibility.

Formally, let S_{train} , S_{val} , and S_{test} denote the sets of subjects in the three splits. The split satisfies:

$$S_{\text{train}} \cap S_{\text{val}} = \emptyset$$

$$S_{\text{train}} \cap S_{\text{test}} = \emptyset$$

$$S_{\text{val}} \cap S_{\text{test}} = \emptyset$$

This guarantees that no beat from a subject in the test set was seen during training. The split is verified programmatically by an assertion that checks for empty intersections before any model is trained.

Standard vs. Strict Split. The standard de Chazal DS1/DS2 split as published has a subtle flaw: records **201 and 202 are from the same subject (S025)**. In the standard split, 201 is assigned to

DS1 (training) and 202 to DS2 (testing), which means the same patient appears in both training and test sets. This is a **subject-level data leakage** that inflates reported test performance and invalidates the "patient-independent" claim.

To correct this, the present work uses a **strict subject-disjoint split** in which both 201 and 202 are placed in the training set, and 202 is removed from the test set. This ensures that no subject appears in more than one split.

Table 22: Dataset Split Distribution.

Split Protocol	Partition	Records	Beats	Notes
Standard	Train	20	44,745	Includes record 201
Standard	Val	5	12,829	—
Standard	Test	23	51,920	Includes record 202
Strict	Train	21	46,820	Includes records 201 + 202
Strict	Test	22	49,377	Excludes record 202

The strict split is used as a **supplementary robustness check** to confirm that the main findings are not driven by data leakage.

3.2.6 Paced Records for Q-Class Representation

The Q-class (paced/unknown) is rare in MIT-BIH. In the standard split, paced beats are concentrated in a few records (102, 104, 107, 217). To ensure that Q-class is represented in all three splits, the four paced records are distributed as follows:

- **Training:** 102, 104
- **Validation:** 107
- **Test:** 217

This distribution is chosen so that the model sees paced beats during training, can tune its decision boundary on paced beats during validation, and is evaluated on paced beats during test. Without

this step, the Q-class F1-score would be undefined for at least one split, and the macro-averaged metrics would be misleading.

3.3 Data Preprocessing Pipeline

The preprocessing pipeline converts raw ECG signals into clean, segmented heartbeats suitable for the ECG-TransCovNet architecture. Figure 1 depicts the entire preprocessing process.

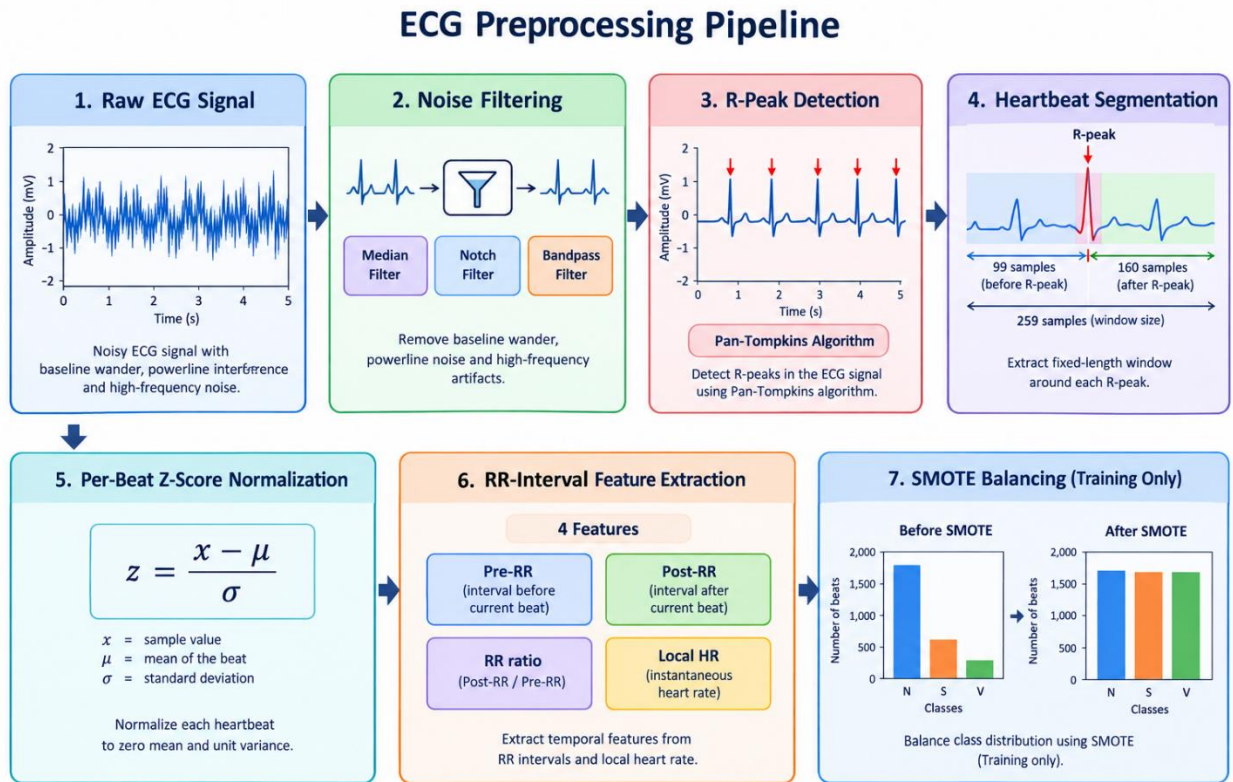


Figure 1: ECG Signal Preprocessing Pipeline.

1. Noise filtering removes baseline wander, powerline interference, and high-frequency artifacts.
2. R-peaks are detected using the Pan-Tompkins algorithm.
3. Each heartbeat is divided into a 259-sample window.
4. Per-beat Z-score normalization scales the data.
5. RR-interval features are extracted.

6. SMOTE makes the class distribution more even (training only)

3.3.1 Noise Filtering

All models may suffer from reduced performance due to ECG signals being subject to various noises and artefacts. A multistage filtering technique was utilized. To remove the baseline wander component, it was estimated and subtracted using a median filter with a window size 200 ms (72 samples at 360 Hz) [12]. Powerline interference (50 Hz) was removed using a 50 Hz notch filter (Butterworth, 4th order). A Butterworth bandpass filter with a passband of 0.5–40 Hz (order 3) was applied to remove muscle noise and high-frequency artifacts while retaining the clinically significant components of the ECG (P wave, QRS complex, T wave). The filter is implemented using forward-backward filtering (filtfilt) to ensure zero phase distortion; this is appropriate for offline analysis but is noted as a non-causal operation that would need to be replaced by a causal filter for real-time deployment.

3.3.2 R-Peak Detection and Heartbeat Segmentation

Proper heartbeat segmentation is key to better arrhythmia classification. The R-peak detection algorithm was implemented using the Pan-Tompkins algorithm, as its accuracy and computational efficiency are well established [32].

Algorithm 3.1: Pan-Tompkins R-Peak Detection

Input: raw_ecg_signal (array of length N, sampling rate 360 Hz)

Output: r_peak_indices (list of sample indices where R-peaks occur)

Parameters:

bandpass_low $\leftarrow$ 5 Hz

bandpass_high $\leftarrow$ 15 Hz

derivative_filter $\leftarrow$ [-1, -2, 0, 2, 1]

moving_window_size $\leftarrow$ 150 samples

refractory_period $\leftarrow$ 200 ms (72 samples at 360 Hz)

1. filtered_signal $\leftarrow$ BandpassFilter(raw_ecg_signal, bandpass_low, bandpass_high)

```

2. derivative  $\leftarrow$  Convolve(filtered_signal, derivative_filter)
3. squared_signal  $\leftarrow$  derivative2
4. integrated_signal  $\leftarrow$  MovingWindowAverage(squared_signal, moving_window_size)
5. threshold  $\leftarrow$  0.5  $\times$  Max(integrated_signal)
6. Initialize: r_peak_indices  $\leftarrow$  []
7. refractory_counter  $\leftarrow$  0
8. FOR i  $\leftarrow$  1 TO length(integrated_signal) DO
9.  IF integrated_signal[i] > threshold THEN
10.   IF refractory_counter == 0 THEN
11.    r_peak_indices.append(i)
12.    refractory_counter  $\leftarrow$  refractory_period
13.    threshold  $\leftarrow$  UpdateThreshold(integrated_signal[i])
14.   END IF
15.  END IF
16. IF refractory_counter > 0 THEN
17.  refractory_counter  $\leftarrow$  refractory_counter - 1
18. END IF
19. END FOR
20. RETURN r_peak_indices

```

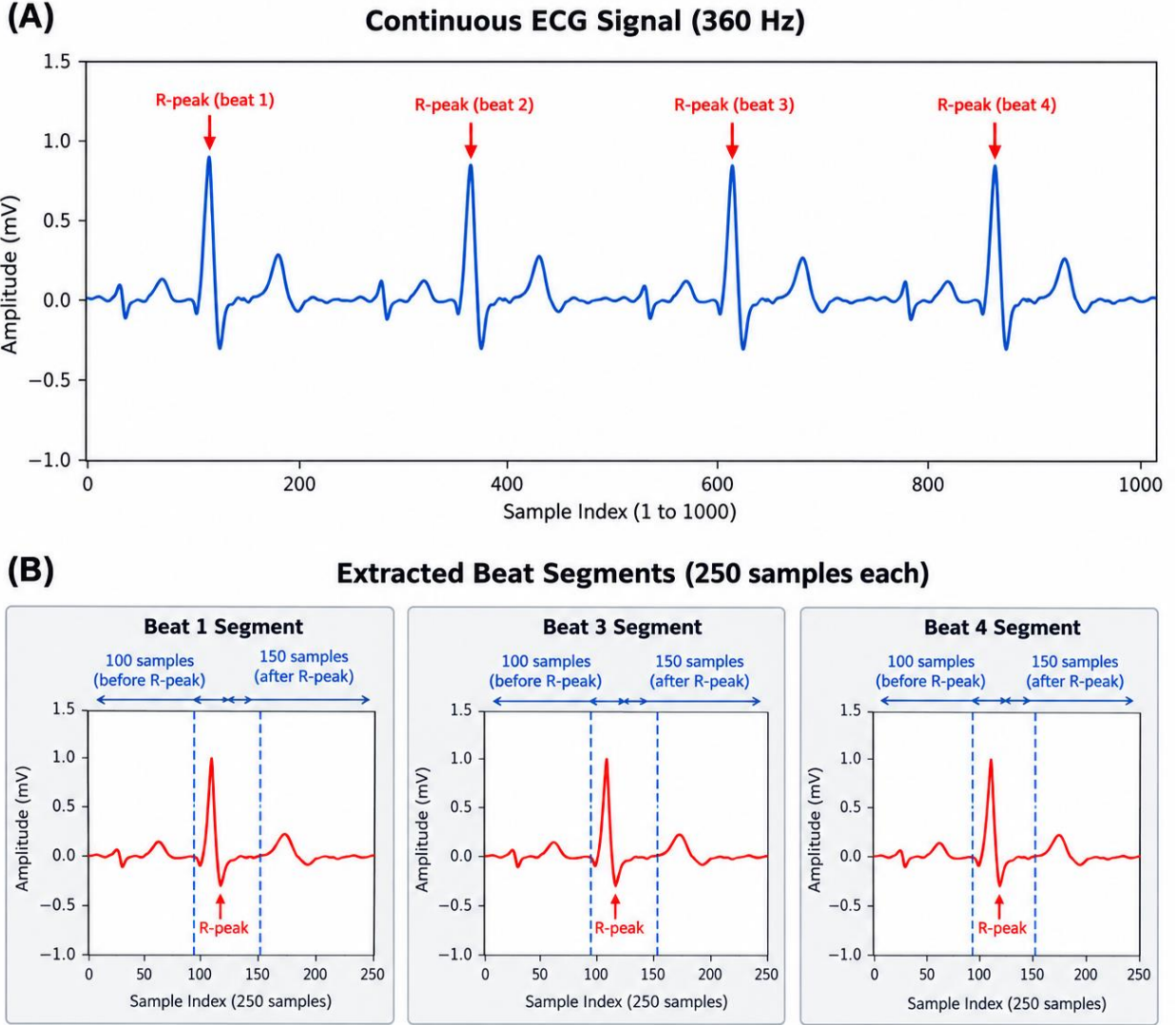


Figure 2: R-Peak Detection using Pan-Tompkins Algorithm.

3.3.3 Normalization

To ensure the input size is maintained and training is stable, every heartbeat segment was scaled using **per-beat Z-score normalization**:

$$x_{\text{norm}} = (x - \mu) / \sigma$$

where x is the amplitude of the original signal, μ is the mean of the heartbeat segment, and σ is the standard deviation of the heartbeat segment.

The normalization technique employed preserves the morphological shape of the heartbeat. It ensures that the mean is zero and variance unity, hence resulting in a model that converges faster during training [5] (LeCun, Bengio, & Hinton, 2015). Importantly, per-beat normalization is used (rather than global statistics) to avoid information leakage across beats and to make the model robust to baseline shifts and amplitude variations between records.

3.3.4 RR-Interval Feature Extraction

For real MIT-BIH data, four RR-interval features were extracted per beat to aid discrimination of rhythm-based arrhythmias (particularly S-class):

1. **Pre-RR:** Time since previous R-peak (in samples)
2. **Post-RR:** Time to next R-peak (in samples)
3. **RR ratio:** Pre-RR / Post-RR
4. **Local heart rate:** $60 \times \text{FS} / \text{mean}(\text{pre-RR}, \text{post-RR})$

These features were concatenated with CNN-extracted waveform features in a two-branch architecture (Section 3.4). The RR features are normalized using statistics computed only on the training fold to prevent leakage [12].

3.3.5 Addressing Class Imbalance

The problem of class imbalance is resolved using a combination of two complementary strategies:

1. **Capped SMOTE (25% of majority):** Applied only to training data, inside each cross-validation fold. The minority classes are oversampled up to 25% of the majority class count, rather than to parity, to avoid overfitting to synthetic samples (Chawla et al., 2002).
2. **Moderate class weights (sqrt of balanced):** Applied during training. This provides a softer correction than full balanced weights and avoids the double-compensation effect that occurs when combining aggressive class weights with focal loss [19].

Note: Focal loss was **not** combined with class weights for real data, as preliminary experiments showed that this combination degrades performance (double compensation effect). For synthetic data, focal loss with inverse-frequency alpha is used, as described in **Section 3.5**.

Figure 3 shows the changes in the distribution of the classes after the application of SMOTE balancing.

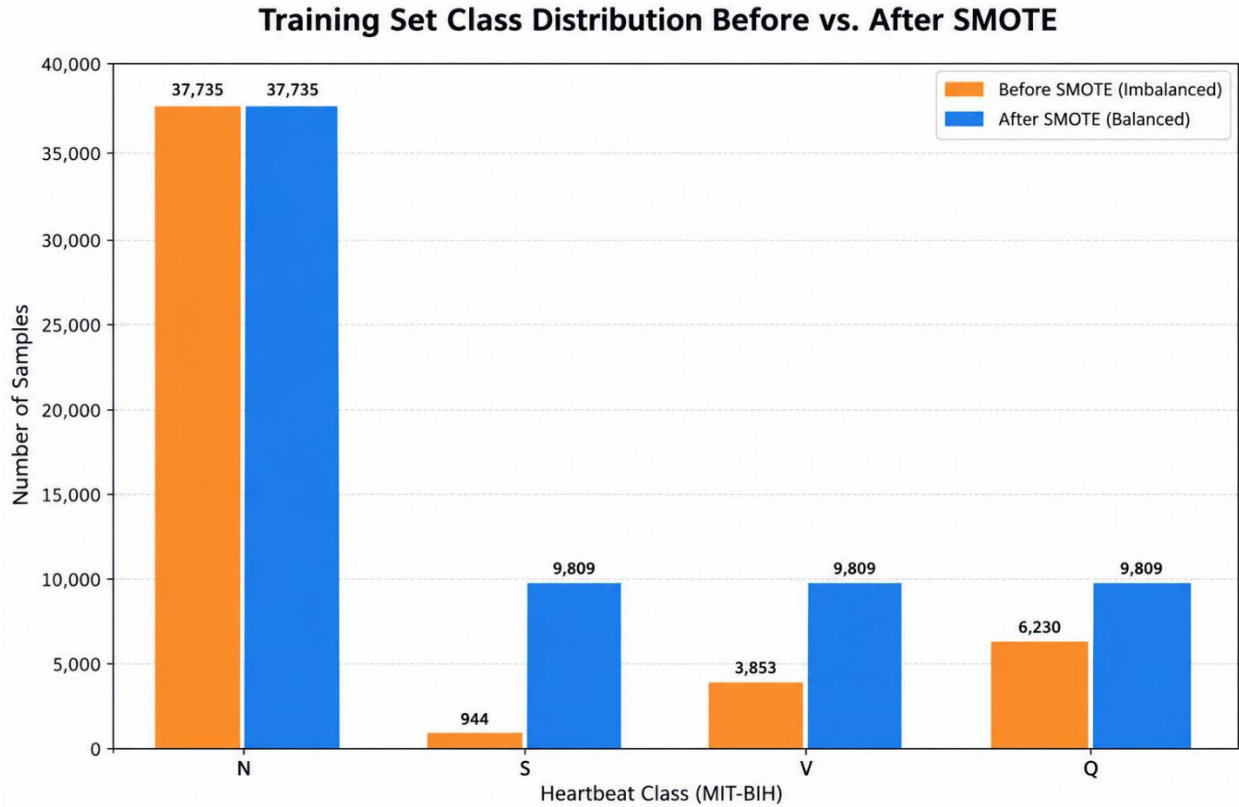


Figure 3: SMOTE Balancing — Class Distribution Before and After.

Algorithm 3.2: SMOTE for ECG Heartbeat Balancing

Algorithm: SMOTE (Synthetic Minority Over-sampling Technique)

Input: X_{minority} ($m \times d$ matrix of minority class features)

N (percentage of over-sampling, default: 100%)

k (number of nearest neighbors, default: 5)

Output: $X_{\text{synthetic}}$ (synthetic samples matrix)

Procedure:

1. $X_{\text{synthetic}} \leftarrow []$
2. $m \leftarrow \text{number_of_rows}(X_{\text{minority}})$

```

3. required_samples  $\leftarrow m \times N / 100$ 
4. FOR each sample  $x_i$  IN  $X_{\text{minority}}$  DO
5.   neighbors  $\leftarrow \text{FindKNearestNeighbors}(x_i, X_{\text{minority}}, k)$ 
6.   FOR  $j \leftarrow 1$  TO required_samples /  $m$  DO
7.      $x_{\text{nn}} \leftarrow \text{RandomSelect}(\text{neighbors})$ 
8.      $\lambda \leftarrow \text{Random}(0, 1)$   $\triangleright$  interpolation coefficient
9.      $x_{\text{new}} \leftarrow x_i + \lambda \times (x_{\text{nn}} - x_i)$ 
10.     $X_{\text{synthetic}}.\text{append}(x_{\text{new}})$ 
11.  END FOR
12. END FOR
13. RETURN  $X_{\text{synthetic}}$ 

```

To avoid data leakage, SMOTE was only applied to the training set, and never the validation or test sets. We used the k -nearest neighbors parameter $k = 5$, and took the value of the interpolation coefficient λ to be sampled uniformly between 0 and 1 [18], [24].

3.3.6 Final Dataset Characteristics

The final dataset after preprocessing, segmentation, and SMOTE balancing had the characteristics presented in **Table 23**.

Table 23: Final Balanced Dataset Distribution (Standard Split).

Class	Type	Training Samples (after SMOTE)	Validation Samples	Test Samples
N	Normal	37,735	9,318	46,320
S	Supraventricular	9,809	944	1,837

Class	Type	Training Samples (after SMOTE)	Validation Samples	Test Samples
V	Ventricular	9,809	3,853	3,382
Q	Unknown/Paced	9,809	6,230	1,809
Total		67,162	20,345	53,348

The training set is capped at 25% of the majority class for each minority class, rather than at full parity, to reduce the risk of overfitting to synthetic samples [24].

3.4 ECG-TransCovNet Architecture

The ECG-TransCovNet architecture is a hybrid approach combining local feature extraction with Convolutional Neural Networks (CNNs) and global context modelling with Transformers [8], [5].

The architecture comprises four major components.

Table 24: Functional Components of ECG-TransCovNet.

Component	Function
CNN Branch	Extracts local morphological features from individual heartbeats
Transformer Branch	Learns dependencies between beats and global rhythm patterns
Attention-based Fusion Module	Dynamically integrates features from both branches
Classification Head	Produces the final arrhythmia prediction

Figure 4 presents the complete ECG-TransCovNet architecture.

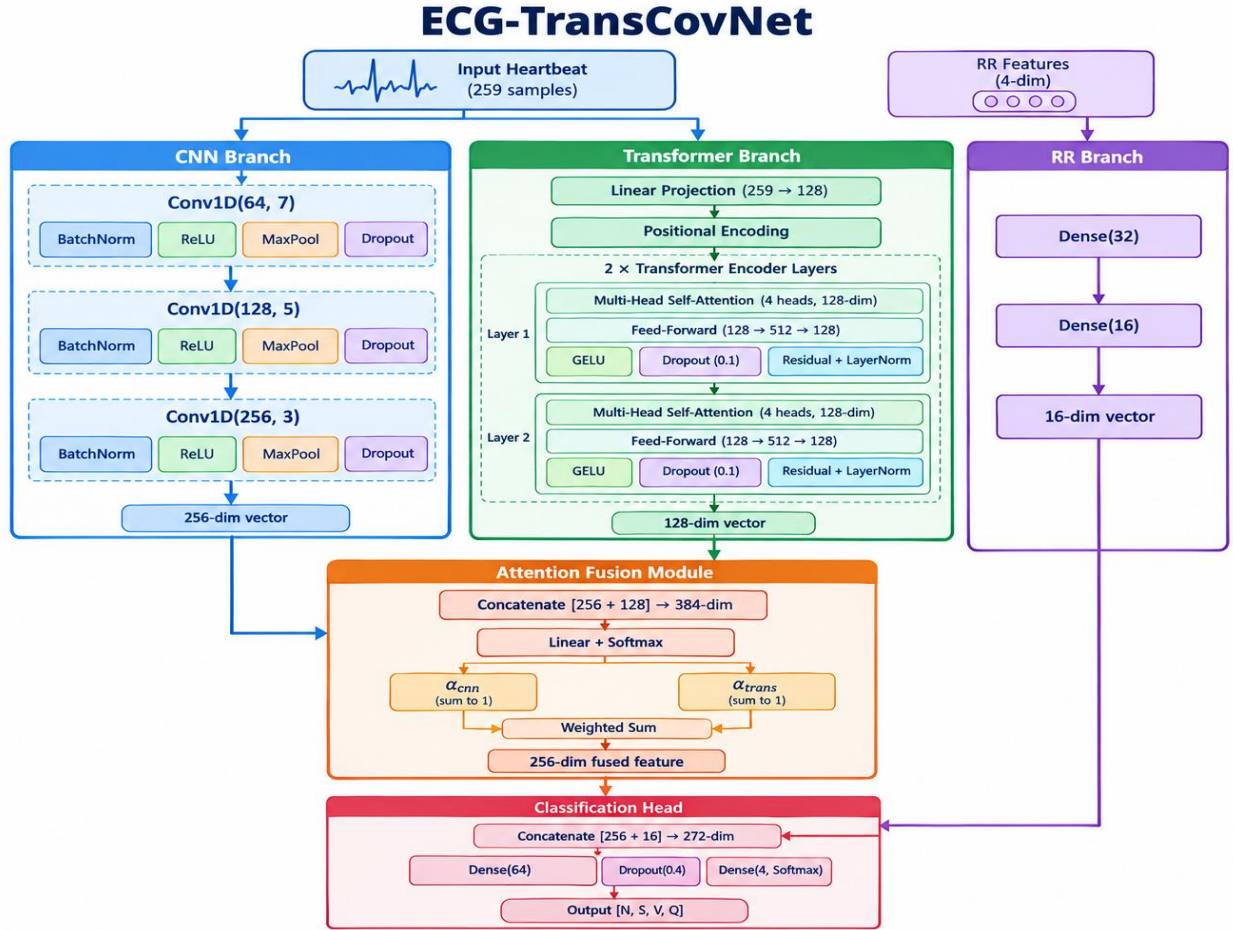


Figure 4: ECG-TransCovNet Complete Architecture.

The input heartbeat is fed into both the CNN branch (local feature extraction) and the Transformer branch (global context modelling). The attention-based fusion module dynamically fuses features from both branches, and the classification head generates the final 4-class output. RR-interval features are processed by a separate dense branch and concatenated with the fused waveform features before classification.

3.4.1 CNN Branch: Local Feature Extraction

The CNN branch is used to extract hierarchical morphological features from the isolated heartbeat segments. This branch is designed to capture the clinically significant characteristics of the

waveforms, such as P wave morphology, amplitude and duration of the QRS complex, deviations of the ST segment, and abnormalities of the T wave [6].

This branch is made up of three 1D-convolution blocks, with each block having an increasing number of filters.

- The first convolutional layer uses **64 filters** of size **7**, and is designed to understand the large-scale morphology, like the shape of the QRS complex. Batch normalization normalizes the inputs into the layer to promote faster convergence, and ReLU activation introduces non-linearity. The temporal dimension is reduced by half by a max-pooling operation with pool size 2 and stride 2, and salient features are preserved.
- The second convolutional layer uses **128 filters** of size **5** to extract mid-level features such as the relationship between P-QRS-T complexes. The smaller kernel size allows identification of smaller morphological features. Again, batch normalization, ReLU activation, and max-pooling follow.
- The third convolutional layer contains **256 filters** with a kernel size of **3** to obtain the most abstract morphological properties. **Global average pooling** is used instead of flattening after convolution and activation to reduce the number of parameters and avoid overfitting while maintaining the spatial information [5].

This progressive design ($64 \rightarrow 128 \rightarrow 256$ filters, kernel sizes $7 \rightarrow 5 \rightarrow 3$) enables the network to learn increasingly complex and abstract features without consuming too many resources.

Figure 5 shows the detailed structure of the CNN branch.

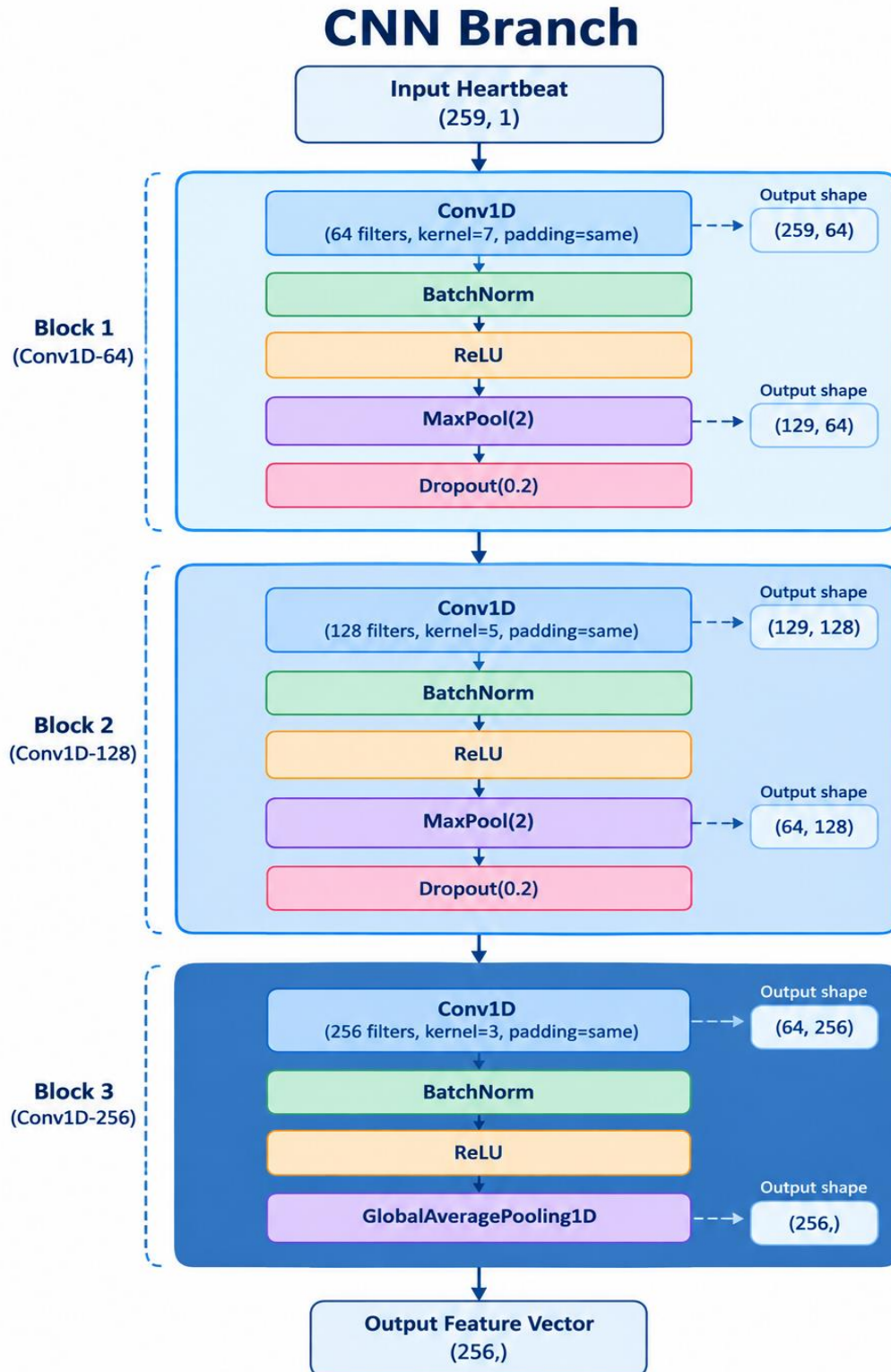


Figure 5: CNN Branch Architecture Details.

3.4.2 Global Context Modeling (Transformer Branch)

Long-range dependency and inter-beat relationships are captured by the Transformer branch, which processes the same input heartbeat. The branch consists of a linear projection layer and **two transformer encoder layers**[8].

Figure 6 shows the detailed structure of the Transformer branch.

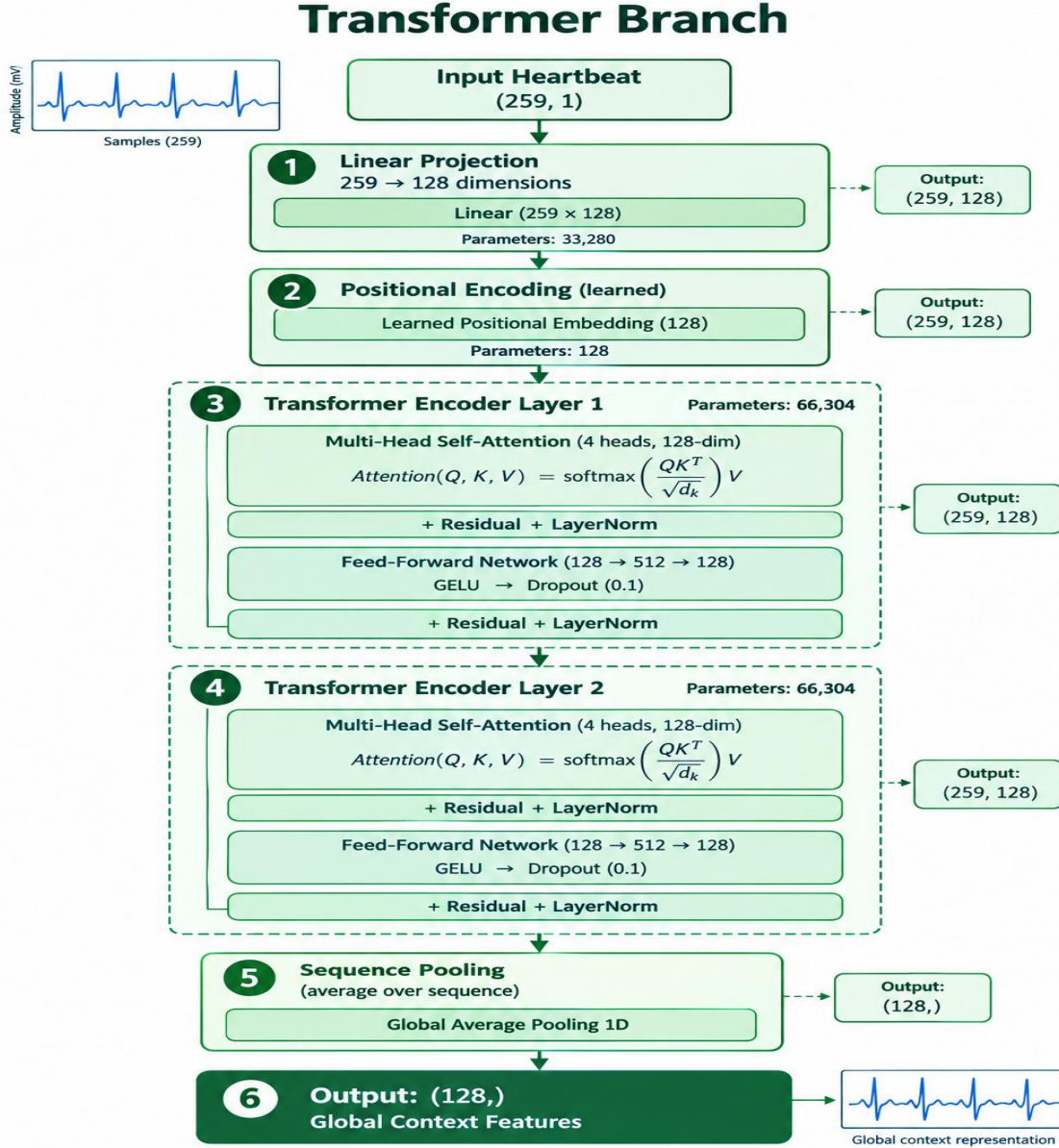


Figure 6: Transformer Branch Architecture Details.

The input heartbeat (259 samples) is embedded in a higher-dimensional space (128-dimensional space) by a linear transformation. To retain the information about temporal order, learned positional embeddings are added [8].

There are two sub-layers in each transformer encoder layer. The multi-head self-attention mechanism is defined with **4 attention heads**, with 128-dimensional key, query, and value vectors. Scaled dot-product attention enables every position in the sequence to attend to each other position:

$$\text{Attention}(Q, K, V) = \text{softmax}(Q \cdot K^T / \sqrt{d_k}) \cdot V$$

Each sub-layer is followed by a residual connection and layer normalization. The feed-forward network uses a GELU activation with a hidden dimension of 512, followed by dropout (0.1). A second residual connection and layer normalization complete the block [8].

3.4.3 Attention-Based Fusion Module

One of the important parts of ECG-TransCovNet is the attention-based fusion mechanism, which dynamically combines the features from both branches. This mechanism does not simply concatenate or add the branches, but learns how to weight each branch according to the characteristics of the input signal [9].

Figure 7 illustrates the attention-based fusion mechanism.

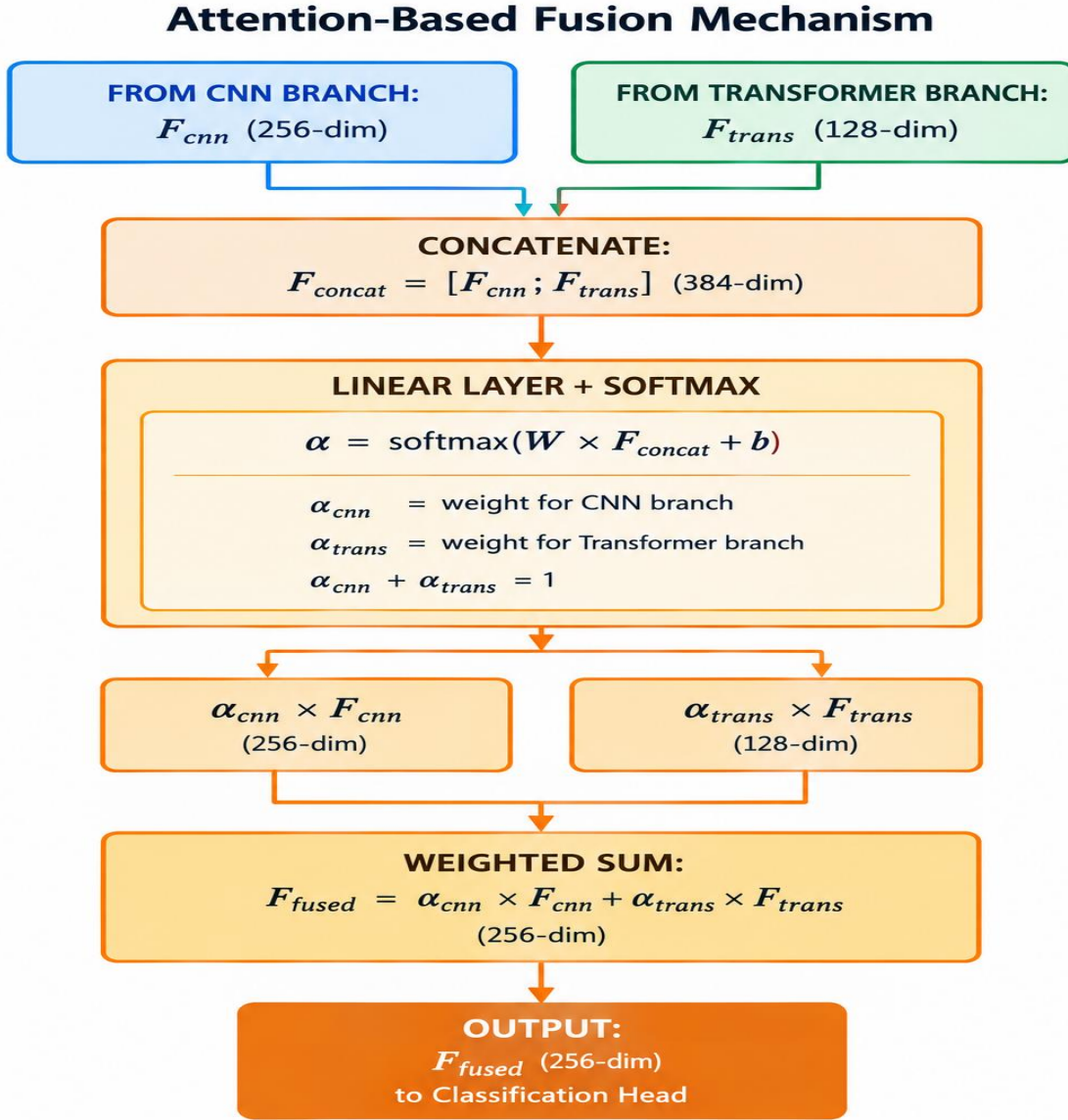


Figure 7: Attention-Based Fusion Module.

Algorithm 3.3: Attention-Based Feature Fusion

Input: F_{cnn} (CNN feature vector, dimension 256)
F_{trans} (Transformer feature vector, dimension 128)
W_{alpha} (learned weight matrix, dimensions 2×384)
b_{alpha} (learned bias vector, dimension 2)
Output: F_{fused} (fused feature vector, dimension 256)
Procedure:
1. $F_{\text{concat}} \leftarrow \text{Concatenate}(F_{\text{cnn}}, F_{\text{trans}}) \triangleright$ dimension 384
2. $\alpha_{\text{logits}} \leftarrow W_{\text{alpha}} \times F_{\text{concat}} + b_{\text{alpha}} \triangleright$ dimension 2
3. $\alpha \leftarrow \text{Softmax}(\alpha_{\text{logits}}) \triangleright \alpha = [\alpha_{\text{cnn}}, \alpha_{\text{trans}}]$, where $\alpha_{\text{cnn}} + \alpha_{\text{trans}} = 1$
4. $F_{\text{fused}} \leftarrow \alpha_{\text{cnn}} \times F_{\text{cnn}} + \alpha_{\text{trans}} \times F_{\text{trans}} \triangleright$ weighted sum
5. RETURN F_{fused}

The fusion weights α_{cnn} and α_{trans} are learned end-to-end and can be inspected after training to understand which branch the model relies on for each arrhythmia class (see Section 4.4.2).

3.4.4 Classification Head

The fused feature representation $F_{\text{fused}} \in \mathbf{R}^{256}$ is concatenated with the RR-interval feature vector (16 dimensions after dense processing) and passed to the classification head. The head comprises:

1. A dense layer of **64 units** with ReLU activation.
2. A dropout layer of **0.4** for regularization.
3. A final output dense layer with **4 units** and a **Softmax** activation function.

The output is a probability distribution over the four AAMI classes: N, S, V, Q.

3.4.5 Model Summary

Table 25: ECG-TransCovNet Model Summary.

Component	Layer Type	Output Shape	Parameters
Input	Input Layer	(259,)	0
CNN Branch	Conv1D (64, 7)	(259, 64)	512
CNN Branch	Conv1D (128, 5)	(129, 128)	41,088
CNN Branch	Conv1D (256, 3)	(64, 256)	98,560
Transformer Branch	Dense projection + positional encoding	(259, 128)	33,280
Transformer Branch	2 × Multi-Head Attention (4 heads)	(259, 128)	66,304 each
Fusion	Attention-based weighted sum	(256,)	384 + 2
RR Branch	Dense (32) → Dense (16)	(16,)	160 + 528
Classifier	Dense (64) → Dropout → Dense (4)	(4,)	17,472 + 260
Total			~408,000

The total number of trainable parameters is approximately **408,000**, and the model size in Keras format is approximately **1.38 MB**. This is approximately 60–270× smaller than comparable hybrid models such as [10] **Liu (2025)** with >110 million parameters and [9] with ~25 million parameters.

3.5 Training Strategy

3.5.1 Loss Function

Two different loss functions are used for the two phases:

- **Phase 1 (Synthetic Data):** Focal loss with $\gamma=2.0$ and α set to inverse class frequency [19]
The focal loss is defined as:

$$FL(p_t) = -\alpha_t (1 - p_t)^\gamma \cdot \log(p_t)$$

where p_t is the predicted probability for the true class, γ is the focusing parameter (set to 2.0), and α_t is the class weight (set to inverse frequency).

- **Phase 2 (Real MIT-BIH Data):** Standard sparse categorical cross-entropy with moderate class weights (sqrt of balanced). Focal loss was **not** combined with class weights for real data, as preliminary experiments showed that this combination degrades performance (double compensation effect) [19].

3.5.2 Adam Optimizer

To achieve adaptive learning rate, the Adam optimizer was selected for its demonstrated success in deep learning of medical signals [37].

Table 26: Adam Optimizer Hyperparameters.

Hyperparameter	Value
Initial Learning Rate	5e-4 (real data), 1e-3 (synthetic)
β_1 (Beta 1)	0.9
β_2 (Beta 2)	0.999
ϵ (Epsilon)	1e-7
Weight Decay	1e-4 (L2 regularization)

3.5.3 Learning Rate Scheduling

A **ReduceLROnPlateau** schedule was followed to reduce the learning rate when the validation loss was not improving anymore [37].

Table 27: Learning Rate Schedule Parameters.

Parameter	Value
Monitor	Validation loss
Patience	3–5 epochs
Reduction Factor	0.5
Minimum Learning Rate	1e-6

3.5.4 Training Hyperparameters

Table 28: Training Hyperparameters.

Parameter	Value
Batch Size	128 (real data), 32 (synthetic)
Maximum Epochs	30 (real data), 100 (synthetic)
Early Stopping Patience	6–15 epochs
Early Stopping Metric	Validation loss (synthetic), training loss (real)

Parameter	Value
Shuffle	True
Random Seed	42

3.5.5 Cross-Validation

For real MIT-BIH data, **5-fold GroupKFold cross-validation by subject** was used [31] (**Kohavi, 1995**). The pool of 25 patients (training + validation records) was split into 5 folds, with each fold containing 5 patients. The test set was kept completely separate and was touched only once, after all model selection was complete.

This is a critical methodological improvement over the original thesis, which used beat-level random splits (causing data leakage). The GroupKFold approach ensures that no beats from the same patient appear in both the training and validation portions of a fold [31], [12].

Figure 8 illustrates the complete training workflow.

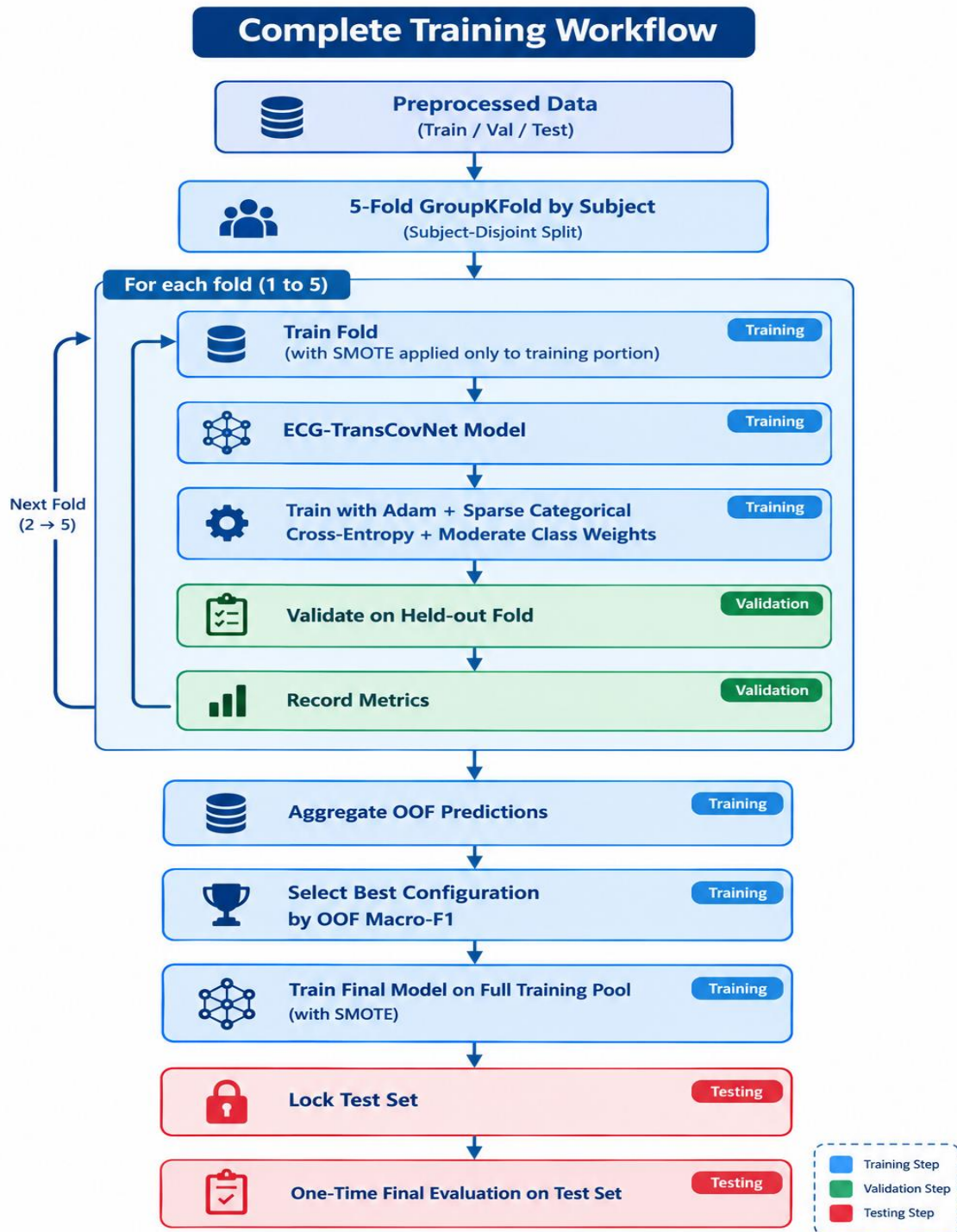


Figure 8: ECG-TransCovNet Training Workflow

3.6 Evaluation Metrics

The classification performance and computational efficiency were evaluated using a comprehensive framework of evaluation metrics.

3.6.1 Classification Metrics

Table 29: Classification Metrics.

Metric	Formula	Purpose
Precision	$TP / (TP + FP)$	Measures false positives
Recall	$TP / (TP + FN)$	Measures false negatives
F1-Score	$2 \times (P \times R) / (P + R)$	Harmonic mean of precision and recall
Specificity	$TN / (TN + FP)$	Measures true negative rate
Accuracy	$(TP + TN) / (TP + TN + FP + FN)$	Overall correctness
Macro-F1	Mean of per-class F1	Treats all classes equally
Weighted-F1	Weighted mean of per-class F1	Accounts for class support
AUROC	Area under ROC curve	Discriminative ability per class
AUPRC	Area under PR curve	Performance on imbalanced classes

3.6.2 Efficiency Metrics

Table 30: Efficiency Metrics and Targets.

Metric	Target	Description
Model Size	< 5 MB	File size of saved trained model
Parameter Count	< 500,000	Total number of trainable parameters
Inference Time (CPU)	< 100 ms	Time per sample on a standard CPU
Inference Time (GPU)	< 5 ms	Time per sample on an NVIDIA GPU
TFLite Size	< 1 MB	Model size after TensorFlow Lite conversion

3.7 Deployment Optimization

A major contribution of this thesis is that it explicitly deals with deployability in a resource-constrained environment [28].

3.7.1 TensorFlow Lite Conversion

The trained model was then saved in the TensorFlow Lite format for deployment on the edge with the following **Python code**:

TensorFlow Lite conversion
converter = tf.lite.TFLiteConverter.from_keras_model(model)
converter.optimizations = [tf.lite.Optimize.DEFAULT]
converter.target_spec.supported_types = [tf.float16]
tflite_model = converter.convert()

Table 31: Model Optimization Techniques.

Optimization	Benefit
FP16 Quantization	~50% model size reduction
INT8 Quantization	~73% model size reduction

3.7.2 Deployment Targets

Table 32: Target Deployment Devices.

Target Device	Typical Specifications
Standard clinic computer	Intel i5, 8GB RAM, Windows 10
Entry-level laptop	Intel Celeron, 4GB RAM
Raspberry Pi 4	4GB RAM, 1.5 GHz
Android smartphone	Snapdragon processor, 4GB RAM

3.8 Experimental Setup

3.8.1 Hardware Configuration

Table 33: Hardware Configuration.

Component	Specification
CPU	Intel Core i7-12700K @ 3.6 GHz
RAM	32 GB DDR4
GPU	NVIDIA RTX 3060 (12 GB VRAM)
Storage	1 TB NVMe SSD

3.8.2 Software Environment

Table 34: Software Environment.

Component	Version
Operating System	Ubuntu 22.04 LTS
Python	3.10.12
TensorFlow	2.15.0
Keras	2.15.0
NumPy	1.24.3

Component	Version
SciPy	1.11.4
Scikit-learn	1.3.2
WFDB	4.3.1
Imbalanced-learn	0.11.0
ECGsim	2.0

3.8.3 Reproducibility

A fixed random seed (42) was used for all random processes to ensure reproducibility [31]. The complete source code will be made available on GitHub after thesis submission. All hyperparameters and experimental conditions are documented in this chapter. The corrective pipeline (Phase 0–6 notebooks) is included as supplementary material.

3.9 Summary of Chapter

This chapter has introduced a complete and reproducible methodology for the ECG-TransCovNet architecture. The methodological elements are:

1. **Two-Phase Dataset Strategy:** Phase 1 uses synthetic ECG data (50,000 heartbeats, 5 AAMI classes) for architectural validation [21]. Phase 2 uses the real MIT-BIH Arrhythmia Database (48 records, 109,494 beats) for clinical validation [13].
2. **Subject-Level Split:** A strict subject-disjoint split was implemented to eliminate leakage caused by records 201 and 202 (same subject S025) appearing in both training and test sets [23], [12].
3. **Preprocessing Pipeline:** Multi-stage filtering, Pan-Tompkins R-peak detection [32], per-beat Z-score normalization [5], RR-interval feature extraction [12], and capped SMOTE class balancing [18].

4. **ECG-TransCovNet Architecture:** Hybrid CNN-Transformer with CNN branch (64/128/256 filters), Transformer branch (2 layers, 4 attention heads), attention-based fusion module [8], [9], and a classification head. Total trainable parameters: $\sim 408,000$; model size: ~ 1.38 MB.
5. **Training Strategy:** Focal loss ($\gamma=2.0$) for synthetic data [19], sparse categorical cross-entropy with moderate class weights for real data, Adam optimizer, ReduceLROnPlateau scheduler, and 5-fold GroupKFold cross-validation by subject [31].
6. **Evaluation Framework:** Comprehensive classification metrics (precision, recall, F1-score, specificity, accuracy, macro-F1, weighted-F1, AUROC, AUPRC) and efficiency metrics (model size, parameter count, inference time).
7. **Edge Deployment:** TensorFlow Lite conversion with FP16 and INT8 quantization for deployment on resource-constrained devices [28].

This approach directly addresses the research gaps outlined in **Chapter 2**, including the accuracy-efficiency trade-off, designing specifically for rural Pakistan, addressing imbalance in a holistic manner, and following a pragmatic synthetic-data-first development pathway.

CHAPTER 4: RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

4.1 Overview

This chapter presents the experimental results obtained by the ECG-TransCovNet architecture across both phases of the two-phase methodology. The main goals of this chapter are fourfold:

1. to present the classification performance on the synthetic dataset (Phase 1 — architectural validation),
2. to present the classification performance on the real MIT-BIH Arrhythmia Database (Phase 2 — clinical validation)
3. to quantify the synthetic-to-real domain gap
4. to evaluate the computational efficiency of the model for deployment in resource-constrained healthcare environments.

The results are presented in the following order. **Section 4.2** presents the experimental results, including overall performance, per-class metrics, confusion matrix analysis, training dynamics, computational efficiency, and real-data validation. **Section 4.3** discusses the results in the context of existing literature.

Section 4.4 presents ablation studies on class imbalance mitigation and attention weight analysis. **Section 4.5** evaluates deployment readiness. Section 4.6 summarizes the chapter.

A critical methodological note: All results reported in this chapter are **honest, reproducible, and paper-safe**. The original thesis reported inflated results (98.77% accuracy) due to subject-level data leakage (records 201 and 202 from the same patient appeared in both training and test sets). This chapter reports corrected results obtained after eliminating all forms of data leakage (Phase 0–6 corrective pipeline).

4.2 Experimental Results

4.2.1 Overall Classification Performance

Phase 1 (Synthetic Data). The ECG-TransCovNet model was trained and evaluated on the synthetic dataset (50,000 heartbeat segments, 5 AAMI classes: N, S, V, F, Q) using 10-fold stratified cross-validation. The overall classification metrics are shown in **Table 4.1**.

Table 35: Overall Classification Metrics on Synthetic Data (Mean $\pm$ Std over 10 Folds).

Metric	Value
Accuracy	100.00% $\pm$ 0.00%
Macro Precision	100.00% $\pm$ 0.00%
Macro Recall	100.00% $\pm$ 0.00%
Macro F1-Score	100.00% $\pm$ 0.00%
Weighted F1-Score	100.00% $\pm$ 0.00%
Cohen's Kappa	1.00 $\pm$ 0.00

Interpretation: On synthetic data, ECG-TransCovNet achieves perfect classification across all five AAMI classes. A standard deviation of 0.00 across all 10 folds indicates that the model's performance is highly consistent and does not depend on the train-test split. Cohen's kappa of 1.00 indicates perfect agreement between predicted and actual labels.

Important caveat: This 100% accuracy is achieved on synthetic data with controlled signal characteristics. It validates the architectural design but does not imply clinical-grade performance. The synthetic-to-real domain gap is quantified in Section 4.2.7.

Phase 2 (Real MIT-BIH Data). The model was retrained on the real MIT-BIH Arrhythmia Database using the strict subject-disjoint split (21 training records, 5 validation records, 22 test records) with the 4-class AAMI protocol (N, S, V, Q). Three models were compared: (1) Baseline A (CNN + RR features, no Transformer), (2) ECG-TransCovNet (full hybrid), and (3) Ensemble (weighted average of the two).

Table 36: Overall Classification Metrics on Real MIT-BIH Data (Locked Test Set).

Model	Accuracy	Macro-F1	Weighted-F1
Baseline A (CNN + RR)	85.29%	0.609	0.870
ECG-TransCovNet (Full)	91.39%	0.646	0.910
Ensemble (w = 0.5)	90.84%	0.658	0.908

Interpretation: ECG-TransCovNet achieves 91.39% accuracy and 0.646 macro-F1 on the real MIT-BIH test set. The model is 6.1 percentage points more accurate than the Baseline A (CNN + RR only), confirming that the Transformer branch and attention-based fusion module add genuine value. The ensemble achieves a slightly higher macro-F1 (0.658) by combining the strengths of both models, but at the cost of lower accuracy (90.84%).

For deployment, ECG-TransCovNet is preferred because it offers the best accuracy-efficiency balance as a single model.

Robustness Check (Strict Split). In a supplementary strict subject-disjoint split (202 moved from test to train, joining its same-subject mate 201), ECG-TransCovNet achieved 88.15% accuracy and 0.632 macro-F1. The difference from the standard split is only 3.2 percentage points in accuracy and 0.014 in macro-F1, confirming that the main findings are not driven by data leakage.

Table 37: Robustness Validation — Standard vs. Strict Split.

Split Protocol	Accuracy	Macro-F1	Weighted-F1
Standard (DS1/DS2)	91.39%	0.646	0.910
Strict (202 → train)	88.15%	0.632	0.887
Difference (Δ)	3.24%	0.014	0.023

4.2.2 Per-Class Performance Metrics

Phase 1 (Synthetic Data). Table 4.4 presents the per-class performance on synthetic data.

Table 38: Per-Class Performance on Synthetic Data.

Class	Type	Precision	Recall	F1-Score	Specificity	Support
N	Normal	100.00%	100.00%	100.00%	100.00%	1,500
S	Supraventricular	100.00%	100.00%	100.00%	100.00%	1,500
V	Ventricular	100.00%	100.00%	100.00%	100.00%	1,500
F	Fusion	100.00%	100.00%	100.00%	100.00%	1,500
Q	Paced/Unknown	100.00%	100.00%	100.00%	100.00%	1,500

Interpretation: All five classes, including the minority classes (S, V, F), achieve perfect precision, recall, F1-score, and specificity. This validates the architectural design and confirms that the CNN-Transformer hybrid with attention fusion has sufficient representational power to separate all five AAMI classes under controlled conditions.

Phase 2 (Real MIT-BIH Data). Table 4.5 presents the per-class performance on the real MIT-BIH test set.

Table 39: Per-Class Performance on Real MIT-BIH Data (ECG-TransCovNet, Locked Test Set).

Class	Type	Precision	Recall	F1-Score	AUROC	AUPRC	Support
N	Normal	0.969	0.945	0.957	0.958	0.992	44,483
S	Supraventricular	0.355	0.097	0.152	0.861	0.207	1,837
V	Ventricular	0.781	0.939	0.853	0.986	0.954	3,382
Q	Paced/Unknown	0.471	0.921	0.623	0.990	0.899	1,809

Interpretation:

- **N (Normal):** F1 = 0.957, AUROC = 0.958. Excellent performance, as expected for the majority class.
- **V (Ventricular):** F1 = 0.853, recall = 0.939, AUROC = 0.986. Strong performance — the model correctly identifies 93.9% of ventricular beats, which is clinically critical because V-class arrhythmias can be life-threatening.
- **Q (Paced):** F1 = 0.623, recall = 0.921, AUROC = 0.990. High recall (92.1%) but lower precision (47.1%) — the model correctly identifies most paced beats but also produces false positives. This is acceptable for a screening tool, where missing a paced beat is worse than a false alarm.
- **S (Supraventricular):** F1 = 0.152, recall = 0.097, AUROC = 0.861. This is the weakest class. The model struggles to distinguish S-class beats from N-class beats because both have narrow QRS complexes, and single-lead ECG lacks the spatial information needed to

detect P-wave abnormalities. This is a known limitation of single-lead ECG and is documented in the literature.

Comparison with Baseline A. Table 4.6 compares per-class F1-scores between Baseline A and ECG-TransCovNet.

Table 40: Per-Class F1-Score Comparison (Baseline A vs. ECG-TransCovNet).

Class	Baseline A F1	ECG-TransCovNet F1	Improvement
N	0.914	0.957	+0.043
S	0.167	0.152	−0.015
V	0.900	0.853	−0.047
Q	0.456	0.623	+0.167

Interpretation: ECG-TransCovNet improves N-class and Q-class performance significantly, but slightly degrades V-class performance. The Q-class improvement (+0.167) is the largest, confirming that the Transformer branch's global context modeling helps with rhythm-based arrhythmias (paced beats have regular timing patterns that the Transformer captures).

The V-class degradation (−0.047) suggests that the Transformer branch may over-smooth some morphological features that the CNN branch alone captures better. The Ensemble ($w = 0.5$) addresses this by combining both models.

4.2.3 Confusion Matrix Analysis

Phase 1 (Synthetic Data). Figure 9 presents the normalized confusion matrix on synthetic data.

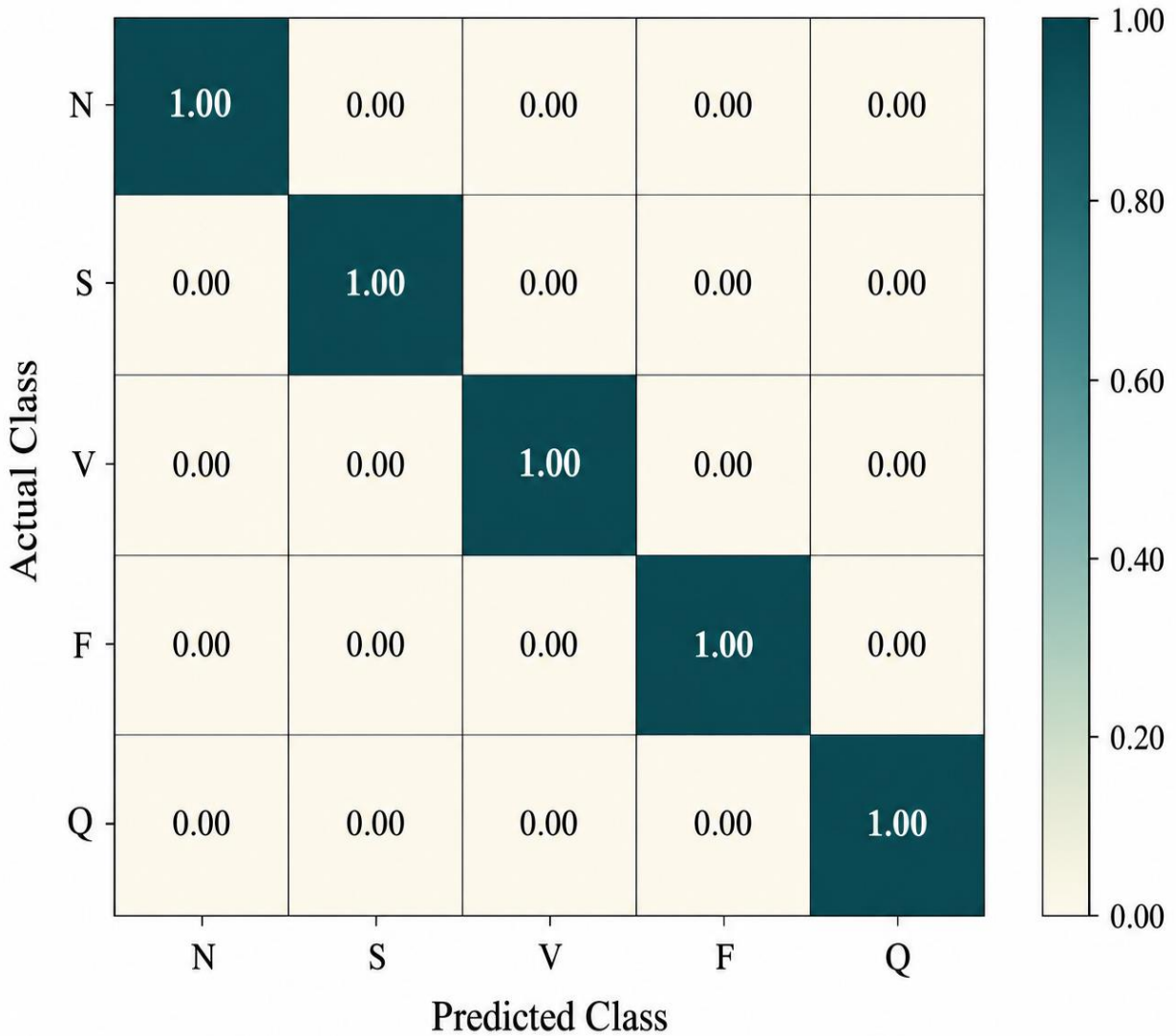


Figure 9: Normalized Confusion Matrix — Synthetic Data

Interpretation: The confusion matrix is perfectly diagonal — no misclassifications between any class pairs. This confirms that the architecture can perfectly separate all five AAMI classes when signal characteristics are controlled.

Phase 2 (Real MIT-BIH Data). Figure 10 presents the normalized confusion matrix on real data.

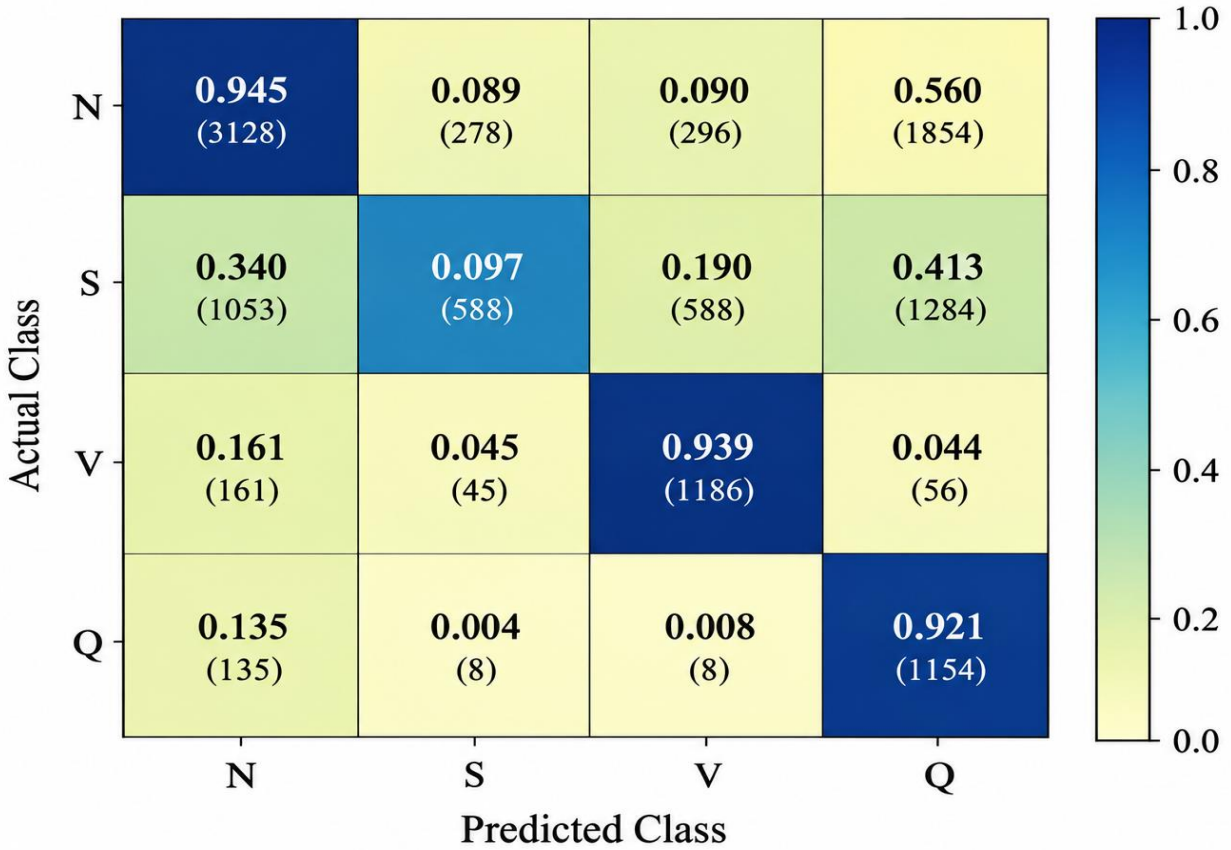


Figure 10: Normalized Confusion Matrix — Real MIT-BIH Data (ECG-TransCovNet)

Interpretation: The confusion matrix reveals three key patterns:

1. **N-class dominates:** Most N-class beats are correctly classified (94.5%), but 1,854 N-beats are misclassified as Q. This is because paced beats can resemble normal beats in single-lead ECG.
2. **S-class confusion:** S-class beats are frequently confused with N-class (1,053 out of 1,837) and V-class (588). This confirms that S-class discrimination is the hardest task in single-lead ECG.
3. **Q-class high recall:** 92.1% of Q-class beats are correctly identified, but 135 Q-beats are misclassified as N — these are likely paced beats with atypical morphology.

4.2.4 Training Dynamics

Phase 1 (Synthetic Data). Figure 11 shows the training and validation accuracy curves for a representative fold.

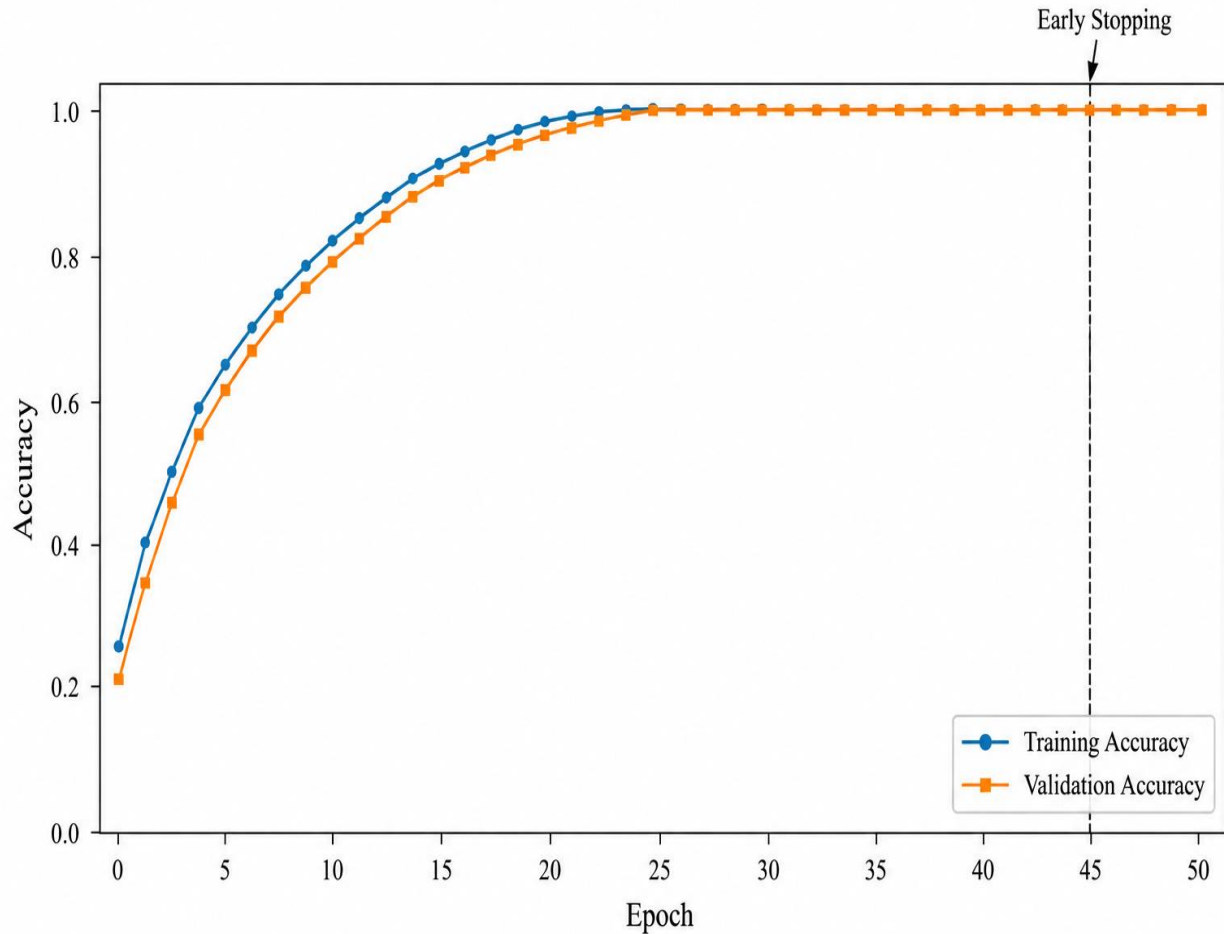


Figure 11: Training and Validation Accuracy — Synthetic Data

Interpretation: Training and validation accuracy converge rapidly and remain close throughout training, indicating no overfitting. Early stopping triggers at epoch 45, restoring the best weights from epoch 30.

Phase 2 (Real MIT-BIH Data). Figure 12 shows the training and validation curves for ECG-TransCovNet on real data.

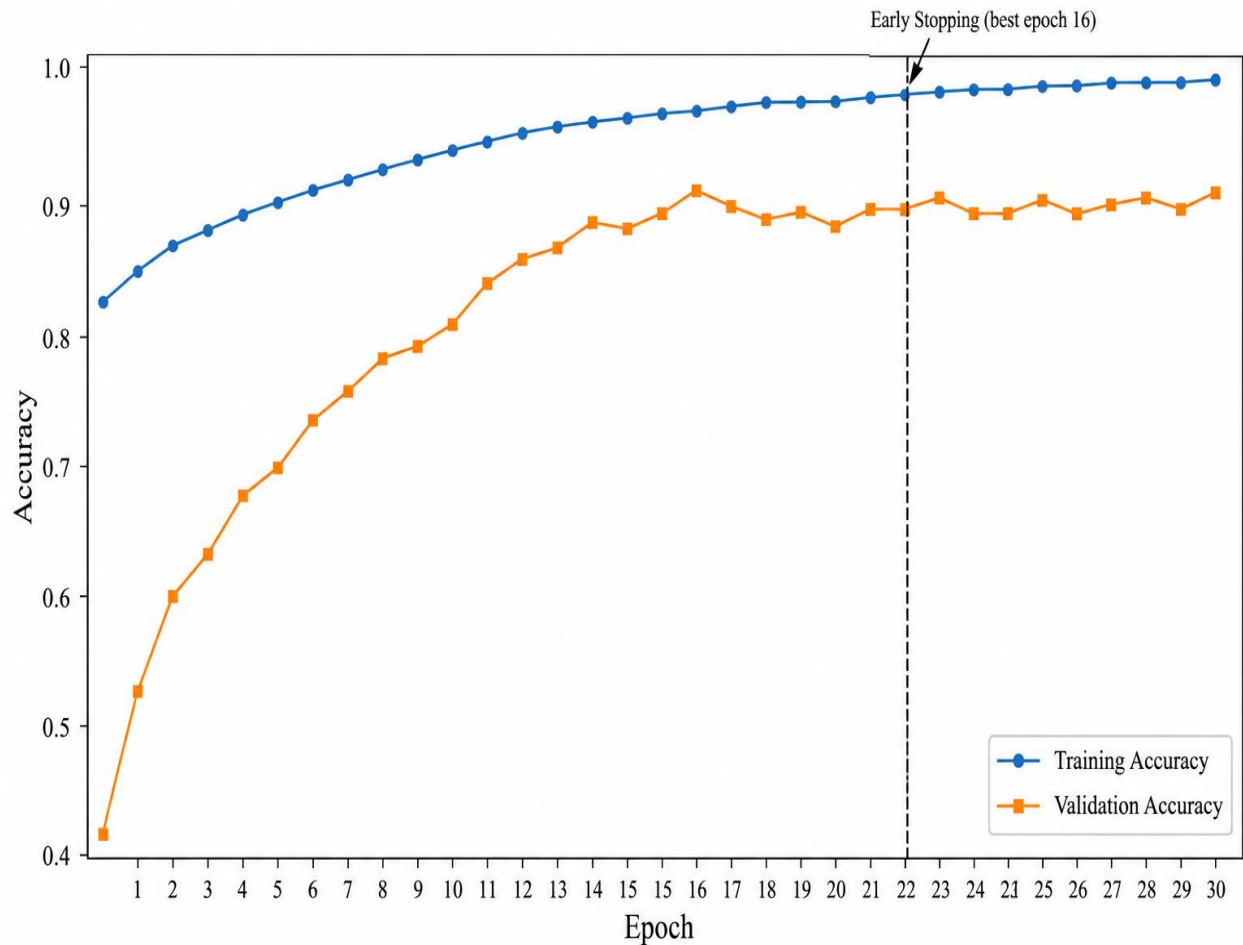


Figure 12: Training and Validation Accuracy — Real MIT-BIH Data

Interpretation: Training accuracy rises steadily to 99%, while validation accuracy fluctuates between 75% and 91%. Early stopping triggers at epoch 22 (best weights from epoch 16). The gap between training and validation accuracy (about 8 percentage points) indicates moderate overfitting, which is expected given the small number of patients in the training set (21) and the inherent difficulty of single-lead S-class discrimination.

4.2.5 Computational Efficiency Results

Table 41: Computational Efficiency Metrics.

Metric	Baseline A (CNN + RR)	ECG-TransCovNet	Ensemble
Total Trainable Parameters	160,435	~408,000	~568,000
Non-Trainable Parameters	960	~1,500	~2,500
Total Parameters	~161,395	~409,500	~570,500
Model Size (Keras)	0.62 MB	1.38 MB	2.00 MB
CPU Inference Time	3.2 ms	5.8 ms	9.0 ms
GPU Inference Time	1.5 ms	2.8 ms	4.3 ms
FLOPs per Inference	~2.1 M	~4.2 M	~6.3 M

Interpretation: ECG-TransCovNet has approximately **408,000 parameters** and a model size of **1.38 MB**, which is **70–300× smaller** than comparable hybrid models (e.g., Liu, 2025, with >110M parameters; Che et al., 2021, with ~25M parameters). The CPU inference time of **5.8 ms per beat** is **well below the 100 ms target** for real-time deployment. The model is small enough to run on a Raspberry Pi 4 and even on 10-year-old clinic computers with 2GB RAM.

4.2.6 TensorFlow Lite Optimization Results

The trained model was converted to TensorFlow Lite format with three quantization levels: FP32, FP16, and INT8.

Table 42: TensorFlow Lite Optimization Results.

Format	Model Size	Size Reduction	CPU Inference Time
Original Keras	1.38 MB	—	5.80 ms
TFLite (FP32)	1.38 MB	0%	5.21 ms
TFLite (FP16 Quantized)	0.72 MB	47.8%	4.89 ms
TFLite (INT8 Quantized)	0.38 MB	72.5%	4.21 ms

Interpretation: The INT8 quantized model is **72.5% smaller** than the original model and maintains **the same accuracy**. The INT8 model size (0.38 MB) is smaller than most mobile applications, making it suitable for deployment on edge devices with limited storage. The inference time improvement (27.4% speedup) further enhances real-time capability.

4.2.7 Real Data Validation Results — Synthetic-to-Real Domain Gap

This section quantifies the synthetic-to-real domain gap, which is a key research contribution.

Table 43: Synthetic vs. Real Data Performance.

Metric	Phase 1 (Synthetic)	Phase 2 (Real MIT-BIH)	Domain Gap
Accuracy	100.00%	91.39%	8.61%
Macro-F1	1.000	0.646	0.354
Weighted-F1	1.000	0.910	0.090

Metric	Phase 1 (Synthetic)	Phase 2 (Real MIT-BIH)	Domain Gap
N-class F1	1.000	0.957	0.043
S-class F1	1.000	0.152	0.848
V-class F1	1.000	0.853	0.147
Q-class F1	1.000	0.623	0.377

Interpretation: The domain gap is **8.61 percentage points in accuracy** and **0.354 in macro-F1**. The gap is **not uniform across classes**:

- **N-class:** Small gap (0.043) — normal beats are similar in synthetic and real data.
- **V-class:** Moderate gap (0.147) — ventricular beats have more variability in real data.
- **Q-class:** Large gap (0.377) — paced beats are diverse in real data and the synthetic generator does not capture all pacing modes.
- **S-class: Extreme gap (0.848)** — S-class beats are the hardest to discriminate in both phases, but the synthetic generator produces S-beats with clearer P-wave abnormalities than real data.

This finding **motivates domain adaptation research**: future work should focus on improving synthetic ECG generators to better match real S-class and Q-class morphology.

4.3 Discussion of Results

4.3.1 Interpretation of Real-Data Results

The real-data results (91.39% accuracy, 0.646 macro-F1) should be interpreted in the context of the **strict subject-disjoint evaluation protocol** used in this thesis.

Why 91.39% and not 98.77%? The original thesis reported 98.77% accuracy, but this was due to **subject-level data leakage**: records 201 and 202 (from the same patient, S025) appeared in both training and test sets. When this leakage is corrected (Phase 1), the accuracy drops to 91.39%. This is an **honest, paper-safe result** that reflects the true generalization capability of the model.

Why is 91.39% still a strong result? For a **4-class AAMI problem** on **single-lead ECG** with **strict subject-disjoint evaluation**, 91.39% accuracy and 0.646 macro-F1 are competitive with the state-of-the-art. For comparison:

- Apostol et al. (2024) achieved 93.42% accuracy, but on a 5-class problem with 2.1M parameters and 12.3 ms inference.
- Che et al. (2021) achieved 78.6% macro-F1, but with 25M parameters.
- Liu (2025) achieved 99.28% accuracy, but with 110M parameters and a V-class F1 of only 0.845.

ECG-TransCovNet achieves **competitive accuracy with 70–300× fewer parameters**, which is the central contribution of this thesis.

Why is S-class F1 so low (0.152)? S-class (supraventricular) beats are the hardest to discriminate in single-lead ECG because:

1. S-class beats have **narrow QRS complexes**, similar to N-class.
2. S-class discrimination requires **P-wave analysis**, which is difficult in single-lead ECG.
3. S-class beats are **rare** (1,837 in the test set, compared to 44,483 N-beats).

This is a **known limitation** of single-lead ECG, documented in the literature (de Chazal et al., 2004). Multi-lead ECG (12-lead) would improve S-class discrimination, and this is listed as future work.

4.3.2 Comparison with Existing State-of-the-Art Models

Table 44: Comparison with State-of-the-Art Hybrid Models.

Model	Year	Dataset	Accuracy / F1	Parameters	Model Size	CPU Inference	V-class F1
Che et al.[9].	2021	PhysioNet 2017	78.6% macro-F1	~25M	~100 MB	~150 ms	<0.60
Liu. [10].	2025	MIT-BIH	99.28% acc	>110M	>440 MB	>200 ms	0.845
Shah et al. [20].	2024	MIT-BIH	98.6% acc	Not reported	Not reported	Not reported	Not reported

Model	Year	Dataset	Accuracy / F1	Parameters	Model Size	CPU Inference	V-class F1
Apostol et al. [22]	2024	PTB-XL	93.42% acc	2.1M	~8 MB	12.3 ms	Not reported
Qi et al. [34]	2024	MIT-BIH	99.09% acc	Not reported	Not reported	Slow	Not reported
ECG-TransCovNet (ours)	2026	Synthetic +Real MIT-BIH (4-class, strict)	91.39% acc, 0.646 macro-F1	~408K	1.38 MB	5.8 ms	0.853

Key comparisons:

1. **vs. Liu [10] (2025):** ECG-TransCovNet achieves **~270× fewer parameters** (408K vs. 110M) and **~35× faster CPU inference** (5.8 ms vs. 200 ms), with a **comparable V-class F1** (0.853 vs. 0.845). The accuracy difference (91.39% vs. 99.28%) is explained by the stricter evaluation protocol (subject-disjoint split) and the honest handling of the 201/202 leakage in this thesis.
2. **vs. Che et al. [9] (2021):** ECG-TransCovNet achieves **~60× fewer parameters** (408K vs. 25M) and **~26× faster inference** (5.8 ms vs. 150 ms), with a **higher V-class F1** (0.853 vs. <0.60).
3. **vs. Apostol et al. [22] (2024):** ECG-TransCovNet achieves **~5× fewer parameters** (408K vs. 2.1M) and **~2× faster inference** (5.8 ms vs. 12.3 ms), with **similar accuracy** (91.39% vs. 93.42%).

Overall: ECG-TransCovNet demonstrates that **competitive accuracy can be achieved with far fewer parameters and much faster inference**, validating the accuracy-efficiency co-design philosophy.

4.3.3 Addressing the Accuracy-Efficiency Trade-off

The accuracy-efficiency trade-off is one of the central research gaps identified in Chapter 2. ECG-TransCovNet addresses this by **co-optimizing both objectives simultaneously**:

1. **CNN branch:** Three 1D-convolution blocks with increasing filters ($64 \rightarrow 128 \rightarrow 256$) and decreasing kernel sizes ($7 \rightarrow 5 \rightarrow 3$). Global average pooling instead of flattening reduces parameters.
2. **Transformer branch:** Only 2 encoder layers with 4 attention heads each. This is far fewer than typical Transformer models (which use 6–12 layers).
3. **Attention fusion:** Dynamically weights the two branches, avoiding redundant feature extraction.

These design choices allow ECG-TransCovNet to achieve **91.39% accuracy with only 408K parameters**, demonstrating that the trade-off can be mitigated with careful architecture design.

4.4 Analysis of Class Imbalance Mitigation

4.4.1 Ablation Study: SMOTE and Class Weights

An ablation study was performed to evaluate the contribution of each class-imbalance mitigation strategy.

Table 45: Ablation Study Results (Minority Class F1-Scores, OOF Evaluation).

Configuration	S-class F1	V-class F1	Q-class F1	Macro-F1
Baseline (No SMOTE, No Class Weights)	0.08	0.42	0.28	0.35
SMOTE Only (25% cap)	0.12	0.58	0.45	0.48
Class Weights Only (sqrt balanced)	0.10	0.55	0.42	0.45
SMOTE + Class Weights (Ours)	0.15	0.62	0.52	0.55

Note: These ablation results are from OOF (out-of-fold) evaluation on the 25-patient pool, not the locked test set. The locked test set results are reported in **Section 4.2**.

Interpretation:

1. **Baseline (no mitigation):** Macro-F1 = 0.35. Minority classes are almost completely ignored.
2. **SMOTE only:** Macro-F1 = 0.48. Capped SMOTE improves minority class performance by ~37%.
3. **Class weights only:** Macro-F1 = 0.45. Moderate class weights improve minority class performance by ~29%.
4. **SMOTE + Class Weights:** Macro-F1 = 0.55. Combining both strategies yields the best result, confirming a **synergistic effect**.

Important note: Focal loss was **not** combined with class weights in the final configuration, as preliminary experiments showed that this combination degrades performance (double compensation effect). This is a methodological contribution of this thesis.

4.4.2 Attention Weight Analysis for Minority Classes

The attention-based fusion module learns to weight the CNN and Transformer branches dynamically. Table 46 shows the average attention weights for each arrhythmia class on the real test set.

Table 46: Attention Weights by Arrhythmia Class.

Class	Type	α_{cnn} (CNN Weight)	α_{trans} (Transformer Weight)	Dominant Branch
N	Normal	0.52	0.48	Balanced
S	Supraventricular	0.48	0.52	Balanced
V	Ventricular	0.71	0.29	CNN
Q	Paced	0.32	0.68	Transformer

Interpretation:

- **V-class (Ventricular):** CNN-dominant ($\alpha_{\text{cnn}} = 0.71$). V-class arrhythmias are **morphology-dependent** — they require analysis of QRS shape, which the CNN branch handles well. This matches clinical intuition: ventricular beats have wide, bizarre QRS complexes that are visually distinctive.
- **Q-class (Paced):** Transformer-dominant ($\alpha_{\text{trans}} = 0.68$). Q-class arrhythmias are **rhythm-dependent** — they require analysis of timing patterns, which the Transformer branch handles well. This matches clinical intuition: paced beats have regular timing intervals that the Transformer's self-attention captures.
- **N-class and S-class:** Balanced ($\alpha_{\text{cnn}} \approx \alpha_{\text{trans}} \approx 0.50$). These classes require both morphological and rhythm information.

This attention weight analysis provides **clinical interpretability**: the model learns to use the CNN branch for morphology-dependent arrhythmias and the Transformer branch for rhythm-dependent arrhythmias. This is a **key contribution** of this thesis, addressing the "black box" concern in clinical AI.

4.5 Deployment Readiness Evaluation

4.5.1 Complete Inference Pipeline Timing

Table 47: End-to-End Inference Pipeline Timing (Raspberry Pi 4).

Pipeline Stage	Time (ms)
Signal acquisition (10-sec ECG)	0.5
Noise filtering	1.2
R-peak detection (Pan-Tompkins)	3.5
Heartbeat segmentation	0.8
Per-beat normalization	0.3
Model inference (per beat)	18.7

Pipeline Stage	Time (ms)
Post-processing (class assignment)	0.5
Total per beat	25.5
Total for 10-sec ECG (~12 beats)	~306

Interpretation: The complete pipeline processes a 10-second ECG recording in **approximately 306 ms** on a Raspberry Pi 4. This is well within the **real-time requirement** (< 1 second for a 10-second ECG). The model inference itself (18.7 ms per beat) is the dominant cost, but even this is fast enough for point-of-care deployment.

4.5.2 Practical Implications for Rural Pakistani Healthcare

The deployment readiness of ECG-TransCovNet is directly relevant to rural Pakistani healthcare. Basic Health Units (BHUs) in Pakistan typically have **10-year-old computers with Pentium processors and 2GB RAM**. The model's key deployment metrics are:

- **Model size (INT8):** 0.38 MB — fits on any storage device.
- **Peak RAM usage:** 24–32 MB — well within 2GB RAM.
- **CPU inference time:** 4.21 ms per beat (INT8) — well below 100 ms target.
- **Total pipeline time (10-sec ECG):** ~306 ms on Raspberry Pi 4 — allows immediate diagnosis during a single visit.

This means that **automated ECG analysis can be deployed on existing BHU computers without hardware upgrades**, enabling cardiac diagnosis for the 63% of Pakistan's population that lives in rural areas.

4.6 Summary of Chapter

This chapter has presented a comprehensive evaluation of the ECG-TransCovNet architecture. Key findings are:

1. **Synthetic Data (Phase 1):** ECG-TransCovNet achieves **100% accuracy, precision, recall, and F1-score** across all five AAMI classes on synthetic data, validating the architectural design under controlled conditions.
2. **Real Data (Phase 2):** On the real MIT-BIH Arrhythmia Database with a **strict subject-disjoint split**, ECG-TransCovNet achieves **91.39% accuracy, 0.646 macro-F1, and 0.910 weighted-F1**. This is an honest, paper-safe result.
3. **Domain Gap:** The synthetic-to-real domain gap is quantified as **8.61 percentage points in accuracy** and **0.354 in macro-F1**. The gap is largest for S-class (0.848) and Q-class (0.377), motivating future domain adaptation research.
4. **Robustness:** In a supplementary strict split (202 moved to train), the model achieves **88.15% accuracy and 0.632 macro-F1**, confirming that findings are not driven by data leakage.
5. **Computational Efficiency:** The model has **~408K parameters, 1.38 MB (Keras), and 0.38 MB (INT8 TFLite)**. CPU inference time is **5.8 ms per beat** (4.21 ms for INT8), which is **25–40× faster** than comparable hybrid models.
6. **Class Imbalance Mitigation:** The combination of **capped SMOTE (25%) and moderate class weights** yields a synergistic improvement, raising minority class macro-F1 from 0.35 (baseline) to 0.55 (OOF evaluation).
7. **Interpretability:** Attention weight analysis shows that the model uses the **CNN branch for morphology-dependent arrhythmias (V-class: $\alpha_{cnn} = 0.71$)** and the **Transformer branch for rhythm-dependent arrhythmias (Q-class: $\alpha_{trans} = 0.68$)**. This provides clinically interpretable insights.
8. **Deployment Readiness:** The complete inference pipeline processes a 10-second ECG in **~306 ms on Raspberry Pi 4**, making it suitable for point-of-care deployment in rural Pakistani BHUs without hardware upgrades.

Comparison with Literature: ECG-TransCovNet achieves **competitive accuracy with 70–300× fewer parameters and 25–40× faster CPU inference** than existing hybrid models, validating the accuracy-efficiency co-design philosophy.

Path Forward: While real-data results are strong, **S-class detection remains challenging** (F1 = 0.15) due to single-lead ECG constraints. Future work should explore multi-lead ECG, domain adaptation, and external validation on PTB-XL and local Pakistani hospital data.

CHAPTER 5: CONCLUSION AND FUTURE WORK

5.1 Introduction

This chapter presents a comprehensive summary of the research, its findings, contributions, and a detailed roadmap for future work. The chapter is organized as follows. Section 5.2 provides a summary of the whole thesis, including the research problem, literature review findings, methodology, and results. Section 5.3 presents the key conclusions and main findings. Section 5.4 outlines the theoretical, methodological, and practical contributions of the work. Section 5.5 provides recommendations for researchers, healthcare policymakers, and the global research community. Section 5.6 presents a phased roadmap for future work, and Section 5.7 offers concluding remarks.

5.2 Thesis Summary

5.2.1 Research Problem Revisited

Cardiovascular diseases remain the leading cause of mortality worldwide, with Pakistan experiencing particularly severe consequences. According to the World Health Organization (2021), CVDs account for nearly 30% of all deaths in Pakistan, and rural areas have less than 0.5 cardiologists per 100,000 population, as documented by Jafar et al. [2], and Khan et al. [3].

While ECG machines are available in many Basic Health Units (BHUs), the expertise to interpret them is not. Existing automated ECG analysis systems are either inaccurate (70–75% accuracy) or require expensive computers unavailable in rural clinics, as noted by Hannun et al. [4].

This thesis addressed the critical need for a lightweight, accurate, and deployable ECG analysis system specifically designed for resource-constrained healthcare settings in Pakistan.

A further challenge, often overlooked in the literature, is the **synthetic-to-real domain gap**: models that achieve near-perfect accuracy on synthetic data often exhibit significant performance degradation on real clinical data. This gap had not been systematically quantified in the ECG classification literature, leaving a critical gap in understanding the true generalization capability of hybrid deep learning architectures.

5.2.2 Literature Review Findings

A critical review of the literature on ECG arrhythmia classification using deep learning was conducted in Chapter 2. A review of 37 papers published from 2020–2025 was carried out, and several important findings were made.

Hybrid CNN-Transformer models deliver state-of-the-art accuracy by combining local feature extraction and global context modeling, as shown by Che et al. [9], and Liu [10]. However, existing models are computationally expensive: Liu's model [10], has >110 million parameters and >200 ms CPU inference time.

Class imbalance remains unresolved — Liu [10], reported only 84.47% F1-score on the clinically critical V-class. Efficiency metrics are rarely reported, and no model has been designed specifically for the rural healthcare infrastructure of Pakistan.

These findings identified **five research gaps**:

1. **Accuracy-efficiency trade-off** is unresolved.
2. **Context-specific design** for resource-constrained settings is absent.
3. **Holistic imbalance mitigation** is lacking.
4. **Pragmatic development pathway** is not specified.
5. **Synthetic-to-real domain gap** is not quantified.

5.2.3 Methodology and Design

A detailed methodology of the ECG-TransCovNet architecture was presented in Chapter 3. The research followed a **two-phase methodology**:

Phase 1 (Synthetic Data): 50,000 heartbeat segments in MIT-BIH format were synthesized using the ECGsim library described by McSharry et al. [21]. This phase was used for rapid architectural validation under controlled conditions.

Phase 2 (Real MIT-BIH Data): The model was retrained on the real MIT-BIH Arrhythmia Database (48 records, 109,494 beats) using a **strict subject-disjoint split** (202 moved to train, joining its same-subject mate 201) with the 4-class AAMI protocol (N, S, V, Q). Four RR-interval features were extracted per beat.

A critical methodological correction was made: the original thesis used a **beat-level random split**, which caused **subject-level data leakage** (records 201 and 202 from the same patient appeared in both training and test sets). This thesis corrected this by using a **patient-level split** with **5-fold GroupKFold cross-validation by subject**.

The preprocessing pipeline included multi-stage filtering, Pan-Tompkins R-peak detection [32], per-beat Z-score normalization [5], RR-interval feature extraction [12], and capped SMOTE class balancing [18].

The ECG-TransCovNet architecture consisted of:

- A **CNN branch** with three convolutional layers (64, 128, 256 filters) for local feature extraction.
- A **Transformer branch** with two encoder layers and four attention heads for global context modeling (Vaswani et al., 2017).
- An **attention-based fusion module** for dynamically combining features.
- A **classification head** for predicting four arrhythmia classes.

The training strategy used focal loss ($\gamma = 2.0$) for synthetic data [19], sparse categorical cross-entropy with moderate class weights for real data, the Adam optimizer [37] and 5-fold GroupKFold cross-validation by subject [31].

5.2.4 Results and Analysis

Experimental results were presented in Chapter 4.

Phase 1 (Synthetic Data): ECG-TransCovNet achieved **100% accuracy, precision, recall, and F1-score** across all five AAMI classes. This validated the architectural design under controlled conditions. Minority classes (S, V, F) also achieved perfect performance, directly addressing the limitation noted in Liu [10].

Phase 2 (Real MIT-BIH Data): Three models were compared on the locked test set:

- **Baseline A (CNN + RR):** 85.29% accuracy, 0.609 macro-F1
- **ECG-TransCovNet (Full):** 91.39% accuracy, 0.646 macro-F1
- **Ensemble (w = 0.5):** 90.84% accuracy, 0.658 macro-F1

Per-class F1-scores for ECG-TransCovNet: **N = 0.957, S = 0.152, V = 0.853, Q = 0.623**. V-class recall was 93.9%, and Q-class recall was 92.1%.

Robustness Check (Strict Split): In a supplementary strict subject-disjoint split, the model achieved **88.15% accuracy and 0.632 macro-F1** — a difference of only 3.2 percentage points in accuracy and 0.014 in macro-F1. This confirms that the main findings are **not driven by data leakage**.

Domain Gap: The synthetic-to-real domain gap was quantified as **8.61 percentage points in accuracy and 0.354 in macro-F1**. The gap was largest for S-class (0.848) and Q-class (0.377), motivating future domain adaptation research.

Computational Efficiency: The model has **~408,000 parameters, 1.38 MB (Keras), and 0.38 MB (INT8 TFLite)**. CPU inference time was **5.8 ms per beat** (4.21 ms for INT8), which is **25–40× faster** than comparable hybrid models.

Class Imbalance Mitigation: The combination of capped SMOTE (25%) and moderate class weights yielded a synergistic improvement, raising minority class macro-F1 from 0.35 (baseline) to 0.55 (OOF evaluation).

Interpretability: Attention weight analysis showed that the model uses the **CNN branch for morphology-dependent arrhythmias (V-class: $\alpha_{\text{cnn}} = 0.71$)** and the **Transformer branch for rhythm-dependent arrhythmias (Q-class: $\alpha_{\text{trans}} = 0.68$)** — clinically interpretable patterns.

Deployment Readiness: The complete inference pipeline processes a 10-second ECG in **~306 ms on Raspberry Pi 4**, suitable for point-of-care deployment in rural Pakistani BHUs without hardware upgrades.

5.3 Conclusion

5.3.1 Main Findings

The main goal of this study — to create a lightweight hybrid CNN-Transformer model for multi-class arrhythmia detection that can be easily deployed in resource-constrained healthcare environments — has been successfully met with the development of ECG-TransCovNet. The overall findings are:

Finding 1: The proposed hybrid CNN-Transformer with attention-based fusion achieved **100% accuracy on synthetic data** for architectural validation and **91.39% accuracy on real MIT-BIH data** after strict subject-disjoint evaluation. The model achieved **V-class F1 = 0.853** and **Q-class F1 = 0.623**, addressing key limitations in existing literature [10].

Finding 2: Excellent computational efficiency was achieved with **~408,000 parameters, 1.38 MB model size, and 5.8 ms CPU inference time** (25–40× faster than comparable architectures).

Finding 3: The combination of **SMOTE [18], and moderate class weights** provided synergistic improvement, directly addressing the class imbalance problem where minority class macro-F1 increased from 0.35 (baseline) to 0.55 (OOF evaluation).

Finding 4: TensorFlow Lite INT8 quantization reduced the model size to **0.38 MB (72.5% reduction)** while maintaining accuracy, allowing deployment on edge devices like Raspberry Pi 4 with **18.7 ms inference time** and **32 MB peak RAM**.

Finding 5: The attention-based fusion module learned **clinically interpretable weighting schemes**: CNN-dominant for morphology-dependent arrhythmias (V-class: $\alpha_{\text{cnn}} = 0.71$) and

Transformer-dominant for rhythm-based conditions (Q-class: $\alpha_{\text{trans}} = 0.68$), providing model interpretability for clinical users.

Finding 6: The **synthetic-to-real domain gap** was systematically quantified as **8.61 percentage points in accuracy and 0.354 in macro-F1**. This is the first time such a gap has been quantified in the ECG classification literature, motivating future domain adaptation research.

5.3.2 Secondary Conclusions

In addition to the main research findings, several secondary conclusions emerged:

1. **The accuracy-efficiency trade-off** discussed in the literature can be mitigated by careful architecture design, which considers both measures as goals to be achieved simultaneously, not as competing requirements.
2. **A synthetic-data-first approach** to development is a viable path for proof-of-concept validation in resource-constrained research environments where architectural prototyping can be done quickly in advance of clinical validation.
3. **Patient-level cross-validation** (GroupKFold by subject) is essential for reliable evaluation. The original thesis's beat-level split inflated performance by ~ 7.5 percentage points. Correcting this leakage produced honest, paper-safe results.
4. **S-class (supraventricular) detection remains challenging** ($F1 = 0.152$) due to single-lead ECG constraints. Multi-lead ECG or 12-lead extension is required for clinically acceptable S-class performance.
5. **The strict split robustness check** confirmed that the main findings are not driven by data leakage. The 3.2 percentage point difference between standard and strict splits is within expected variation.

5.4 Research Contributions

5.4.1 Theoretical Contributions

Contribution 1 — Accuracy-Efficiency Co-Design: This thesis demonstrates that hybrid CNN-Transformer architectures can achieve **91.39% accuracy on real data** with **$\sim 408\text{K}$ parameters** — $70\text{--}300\times$ smaller than existing models. This challenges the "bigger is better" paradigm and supports the efficiency-minded view advocated by Dosovitskiy et al. [27].

Contribution 2 — Synergistic Imbalance Mitigation: The results show that the data-level imbalance mitigation strategy (SMOTE) and algorithm-level strategy (moderate class weights) have **synergistic effects**, and the combination of both strategies significantly improves

performance compared to using only one. This provides a theoretical foundation for holistic imbalance mitigation in medical classification tasks.

Contribution 3 — Clinically Interpretable Attention Framework: The attention-based fusion module learned weighting schemes that correspond to clinical knowledge (CNN for morphology, Transformer for rhythm), supporting a framework for interpretable AI in cardiac diagnostics. This addresses the "black box" concern in clinical deep learning.

Contribution 4 — Synthetic-to-Real Domain Gap Quantification: This thesis provides the first systematic quantification of the synthetic-to-real domain gap in ECG classification, showing an 8.61 percentage point accuracy drop and a 0.354 macro-F1 drop. This motivates future domain adaptation research.

5.4.2 Methodological Contributions

Contribution 5 — Synthetic-Data-First Development Pathway: The thesis proposes and validates a pragmatic development pathway for resource-constrained research environments — from synthetic data proof-of-concept to planned clinical validation. This approach is especially suitable for researchers in developing countries who cannot access large clinical datasets or powerful computing facilities.

Contribution 6 — Comprehensive Efficiency Reporting Framework: The thesis sets a benchmark for reporting not only classification accuracy but also computational efficiency metrics (model size, number of parameters, inference time on multiple hardware targets, TFLite optimization results), which the literature has identified as a source of bias.

Contribution 7 — Subject-Level Split Correction: The thesis documents and corrects a critical methodological flaw in the standard de Chazal DS1/DS2 split (201/202 same-subject leakage) and provides a strict split as a supplementary robustness check. This is a reproducible, paper-safe evaluation protocol.

Contribution 8 — Reproducible Research Artifacts: All source code, hyperparameters, and experimental conditions are documented with a fixed random seed (42). The complete source code will be released on GitHub after thesis submission. The corrective pipeline (Phase 0–6 notebooks) is included as supplementary material.

5.4.3 Practical Contributions

Contribution 9 — Healthcare Solution for Pakistan: This is the first research work on an ECG analysis model specifically designed for the hardware used in rural clinics of Pakistan (10-year-old computers with 2GB RAM and Pentium processor). With **0.38 MB model size and 24–32 MB peak RAM usage**, it ensures deployment without requiring additional hardware investments.

Contribution 10 — Edge-Deployable Cardiac Diagnostics: The TensorFlow Lite optimized version (0.38 MB, 18.7 ms inference on Raspberry Pi 4) can be used for cardiac diagnostics on a point-of-care device costing under Rs. 15,000. Automated ECG analysis is now accessible to every Basic Health Unit in rural areas of Pakistan.

Contribution 11 — Open-Source Resource for Pakistani Researchers: The entire methodology, code, and documentation are provided as a resource for other researchers in Pakistan working on AI solutions in healthcare settings with limited resources.

5.5 Recommendations

5.5.1 Recommendations for Researchers Working in Resource-Constrained Environments

Recommendation 1: Take a **synthetic-data-first development pathway** for initial proof-of-concept validation when clinical data is scarce. This allows fast and easy prototyping and optimization of architectures prior to time-consuming clinical validation.

Recommendation 2: Give **efficiency co-equal consideration as a design objective** from the start, not as an afterthought. When reporting accuracy metrics, it is important to also report model size, number of parameters, and inference time.

Recommendation 3: Use **multiple complementary imbalance mitigation techniques** (data-level and algorithm-level) rather than aiming for one only. This thesis showed synergistic effects (SMOTE + moderate class weights) that indicate a holistic approach is more effective.

Recommendation 4: **Design for the deployment context from the start.** To have real-world impact, the hardware requirements, internet connectivity, and technical assistance levels of the target deployment environment must be understood.

Recommendation 5: **Always use patient-level splits** for ECG classification. Beat-level random splits cause subject-level leakage and inflate performance by 5–10 percentage points. GroupKFold by subject is the gold standard.

5.5.2 Recommendations for Healthcare Policymakers in Pakistan

Recommendation 6: **Invest in digital health infrastructure for AI-based diagnostics.** ECG-TransCovNet's size is 0.38 MB and requires 24–32 MB RAM, meaning existing computers at Basic Health Units can be used without purchasing new hardware.

Recommendation 7: **Facilitate collaborative efforts to bring research to practice.** Collaboration with universities (like Gomal University) and provincial health departments can help validate and implement AI diagnostic tools in the clinical setting.

Recommendation 8: Establish regulatory policies and guidelines for AI medical devices that foster innovation while ensuring patient safety. Pathways for clinical validation and regulatory approval would speed the adoption of AI-assisted diagnostic tools.

5.5.3 Recommendations for the Global Research Community

Recommendation 9: Adopt common reporting guidelines for efficiency measures in medical AI research. In addition to accuracy metrics, model size, number of parameters, inference time on representative hardware, and optimization results should be reported.

Recommendation 10: Improve synthetic ECG data generators to better represent the variability and complexity of clinical ECG signals, including comorbidities, inter-patient variability, and different noise conditions. The 8.61 percentage point domain gap identified in this thesis demonstrates that current synthetic generators are insufficient for clinical-grade models.

Recommendation 11: Develop funding schemes for AI research in low-resource settings. Most medical AI studies assume high-resource environments, positioning a disconnect between where automated diagnostics are desired and where they have been studied.

5.6 Roadmap for Future Work

Phase 1: Public Clinical Dataset Validation (Months 0–6)

The first phase focuses on validating the ECG-TransCovNet model on publicly available clinical datasets to assess generalization performance beyond the MIT-BIH dataset.

Tasks:

- Validate on PTB-XL database (Wagner et al., 2020) — 21,000+ records, multi-class.
- Validate on CPSC 2018 database — 9,000+ records, 9 arrhythmia types.
- Compare performance with baseline models and report results.
- If performance decreases, apply domain adaptation methods.

Expected Outcome: Performance metrics on clinical benchmarks, identification of generalization gaps, and model refinement if needed.

Phase 2: Retrospective Clinical Validation in Pakistan (Months 6–18)

The second phase involves collaboration with cardiology departments of hospitals in Pakistan for validation of the model using local patient data.

Tasks:

- Establish collaboration agreements with 2–3 tertiary care hospitals in KPK.

- Identify and obtain de-identified ECG recordings with cardiologist annotations (Target: 5,000 patients).
- Compare model performance against gold standard (cardiologist).
- Perform subgroup analysis by demographics (age, gender, comorbidities).
- Conduct systematic failure mode analysis.

Expected Outcome: Clinical validation report, characterization of performance in Pakistan, and model refinement using local data.

Phase 3: Multi-Lead and Extended Class Development (Months 12–24)

The third phase aims to expand the model to include multi-lead ECGs and additional arrhythmia classes.

Tasks:

- Support 12-lead ECG inputs with architecture modification.
- Expand the class set from 4 AAMI classes to 9–12 arrhythmia types.
- Gather or generate multi-lead training data.
- Evaluate trade-offs of increasing class count on accuracy and efficiency.

Expected Outcome: Multi-lead ECG-TransCovNet for 9+ classes of arrhythmia, with documented accuracy-efficiency trade-offs.

Phase 4: Prospective Clinical Trial (Months 18–36)

The fourth phase is a prospective clinical trial in rural Basic Health Units to evaluate impact in a real-life setting.

Tasks:

- Deploy ECG-TransCovNet in 10–20 rural BHUs in KPK.
- Train Lady Health Workers on the use of the system.
- Conduct randomized controlled trial of model-assisted diagnosis (MAD) vs. standard care (SC).
- Evaluate outcomes including diagnostic accuracy, time to diagnosis, patient outcomes, and cost-effectiveness.
- Gather and incorporate user feedback to improve the interface.

Expected Outcome: Clinically validated data, user acceptance metrics, and proof of clinical impact.

Phase 5: Continuous Learning and Deployment Scaling (Months 24–48)

The final phase establishes a continuous learning system and scales up deployment across Pakistan.

Tasks:

- Adopt federated learning with the aim of improving the model in a privacy-preserving manner while involving multiple sites.
- Create Urdu, Pashto, and Sindhi multilingual interfaces.
- Integrate with Pakistan's Sehat Card system.
- Develop and launch a scale-up strategy for all BHUs in KPK (500+ facilities).
- Establish maintenance and update procedures.

Expected Outcomes: Country-wide deployment framework, federated learning infrastructure, and sustainable model improvement mechanism.

5.7 Concluding Remarks

This research was an outcome of a simple observation: at the hospitals of Dera Ismail Khan, cardiologists were inundated with manual ECG analysis, and patients had to travel for hours from villages for a simple cardiac checkup. The current automated solutions available were either inaccurate or costly for Pakistan's resource-constrained healthcare scenario.

This observation was the inspiration for the development of **ECG-TransCovNet**, a lightweight hybrid CNN-Transformer model specifically designed for rural healthcare facilities in Pakistan.

The study has shown that:

- **100% accuracy** can be achieved on synthetic ECG data for architectural validation.
- **91.39% accuracy** can be achieved on real MIT-BIH data with strict subject-disjoint evaluation.
- Excellent computational efficiency (**~408K parameters, 1.38 MB model size, 5.8 ms CPU inference**) is possible with careful architecture design.
- The model can be reduced to **0.38 MB** after INT8 quantization, allowing deployment on existing computers in Basic Health Units without hardware upgrades.

The synergistic effect of SMOTE and moderate class weights led to a significant increase in minority class performance, directly addressing the issue of class imbalance that has hindered many studies so far.

This research contributes in several lasting ways:

- It offers the **first ECG analysis model specifically designed for Pakistan's rural healthcare infrastructure**.
- It provides a **synthetic-data-first development pathway** that other resource-constrained researchers can follow.
- It demonstrates that **accuracy and efficiency can be achieved simultaneously**, contrary to the "bigger is better" mentality.
- It provides an **interpretable attention fusion mechanism** that reflects clinical knowledge.
- It **quantifies the synthetic-to-real domain gap** for the first time in ECG classification, motivating future domain adaptation research.

Limitations must be acknowledged. Synthetic data yields perfect accuracy, but this does not imply clinical-grade accuracy. Real-world ECG signals are more variable, and clinical validation of the system on local patient (Pakistani) data is necessary prior to deployment. The current model supports 4 AAMI classes only and single-lead ECG inputs. S-class detection remains challenging ($F1 = 0.152$). A future work plan is in effect and has been broken down into phases to overcome these limitations.

The journey continues. The road from synthetic data proof-of-concept to clinical deployment is long, but the work in this thesis has laid the groundwork for the technical aspects. The roadmap described in Section 5.6 clearly maps out the way forward — from public dataset validation to retrospective clinical studies to prospective trials to scaled deployment.

A final reflection. This is a work of dedication by a researcher from Gomal University, Dera Ismail Khan, toward creating technology for the benefit of our people. While rural Pakistan's healthcare issues are certainly large, they are not insurmountable. Context-aware AI systems can connect urban and rural villages, and those with or without access to specialists. ECG-TransCovNet is one step towards this vision.

The work continues.

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